

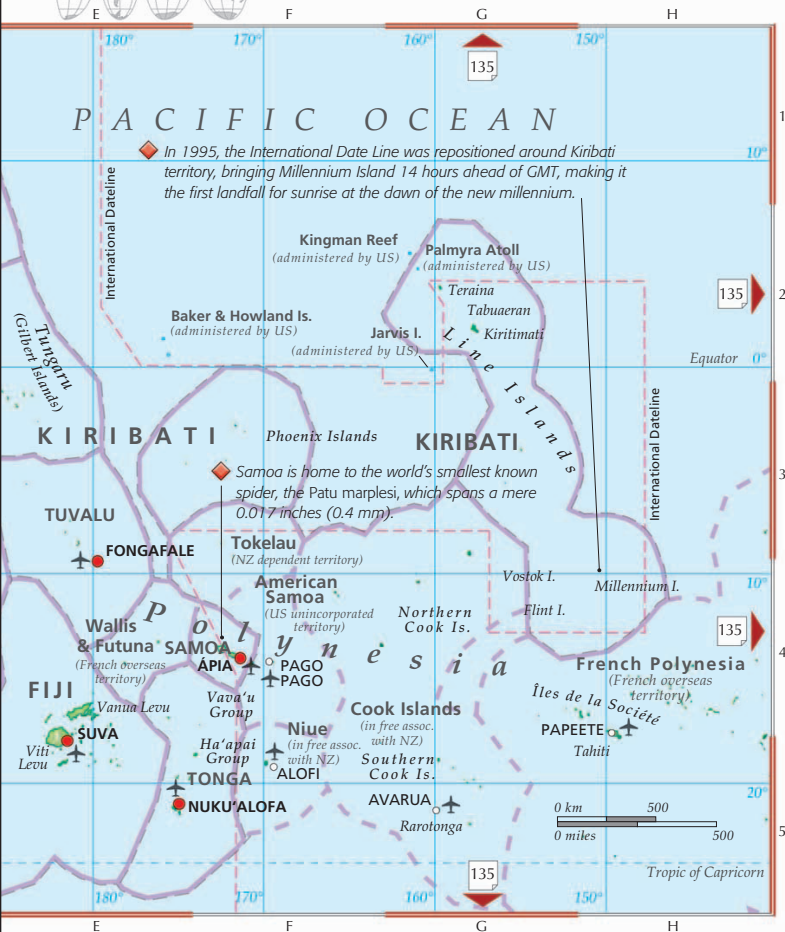
# Australasia & Oceania





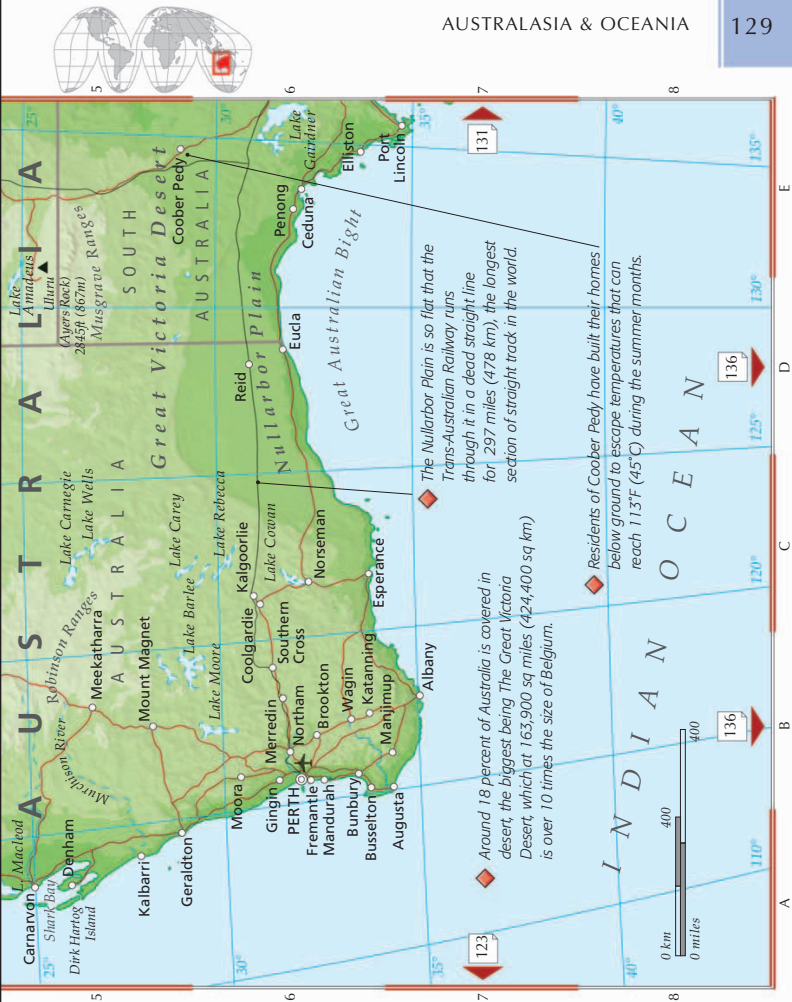
# The Southwest Pacific





# Western Australia





# Eastern Australia





# New Zealand



The lizardlike tuatara is found on some of the islands and rocky stacks off New Zealand. It is the sole remaining representative of the reptilian order Sphenodontia, which first evolved before the dinosaurs. It has a third "eye" on the top of its head, which is sensitive to light.

Ninety Mile Beach is in fact only about 55 miles (88 km) long. Nevertheless, this still makes it one of the longest sandy beaches in the world.

Around 130 CE, something in the order of 33 billion tons (tonnes) of pumice was ejected in a massive volcanic eruption that left a 20,000 sq mile (51,800 sq km) debris field and created an enormous caldera that subsequently became Lake Taupo.

More than 46 million sheep thrive in New Zealand's mild climate, outnumbering the human population by 12 to 1.

## NEW ZEALAND

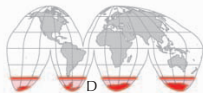


# The Pacific Ocean





## Antarctica





# Arctic



# The world factfiles





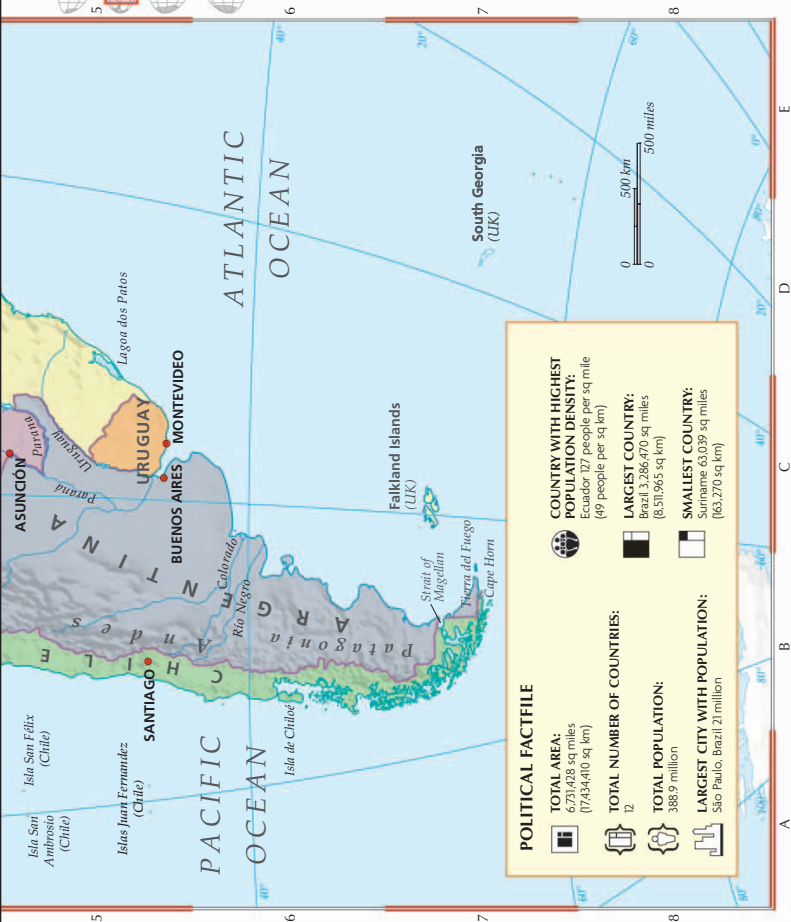
# North & Central America





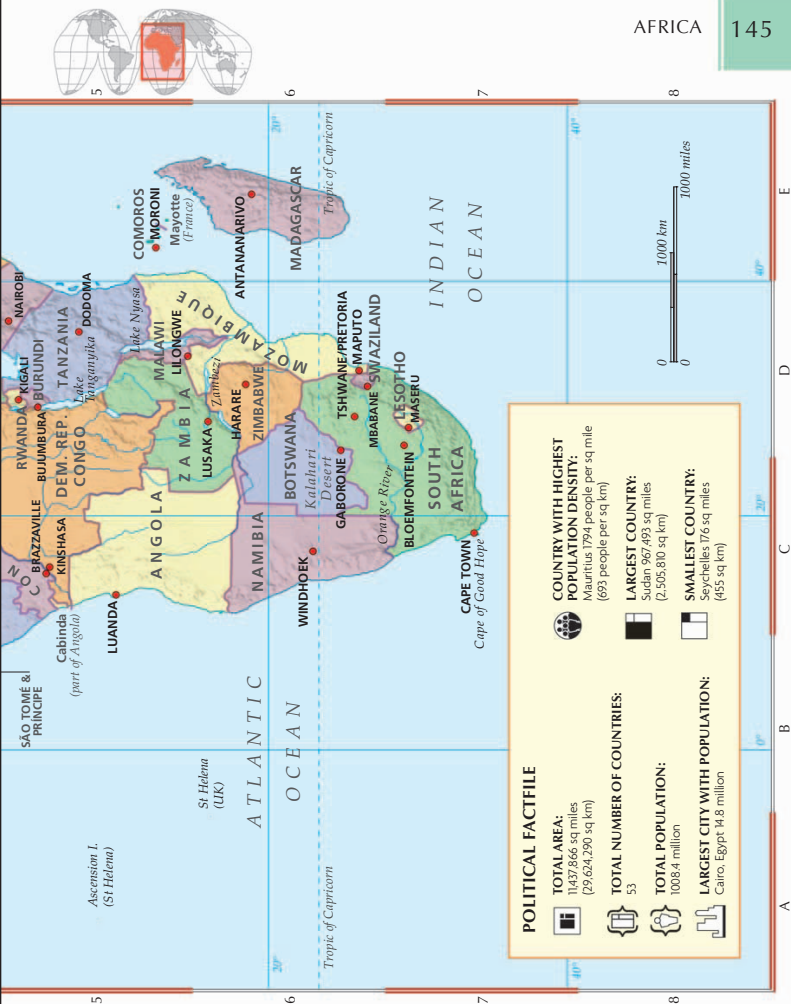
# South America





## Africa





# Europe

## POLITICAL FACTFILE



TOTAL AREA:

3,739,678 sq miles  
(9,685,756 sq km )



TOTAL NUMBER OF COUNTRIES:

46



**TOTAL POPULATION:**

717.8 million



**LARGEST CITY WITH POPULATION:**

Moscow, European Russia 13.5 million



COUNTRY WITH HIGHEST

**POPULATION DENSITY:**  
Monaco 42,667 people per sq mile  
(16,410 people per sq km)



**LARGEST COUNTRY:**

European Russia 1,527,341 sq miles  
(3,955,818 sq km)



**SMALLEST COUNTRY:**

Vatican City, Italy 0.17 sq miles  
(0.44 sq km)





## Asia





## POLITICAL FACTFILE



### TOTAL AREA:

17,006,354 sq miles  
(44,046,472 sq km)



### TOTAL NUMBER OF COUNTRIES:

49



### TOTAL POPULATION:

4148.4 million



### LARGEST CITY WITH POPULATION:

Tokyo, Japan 33.8 million



### COUNTRY WITH HIGHEST POPULATION DENSITY:

Singapore 20,072 people per sq mile  
(7765 people per sq km)



### LARGEST COUNTRY:

Asiatic Russia 5,065,394 sq miles  
(13,119,382 sq km)



### SMALLEST COUNTRY:

Maldives 116 sq miles  
(300 sq km)

# Australasia & Oceania





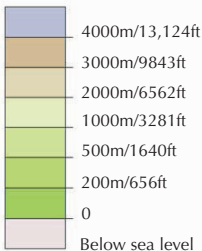
# Key to factfile maps

## FOREWORD

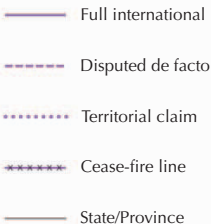
This factfile is intended as a guide to a world that is continually changing as political fashions and personalities come and go. Nevertheless, all the material in these factfiles has been researched from the most up-to-date and authoritative sources to give an incisive portrait of the geographical, social, and economic characteristics that make each country unique.

## KEY TO MAP SYMBOLS

### ELEVATION



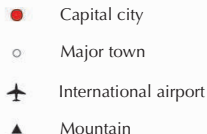
### BORDERS



### DRAINAGE FEATURES



### SYMBOLS



*The asterisk in the Factfile denotes the country's official language(s)*

*Date of formation denotes the date of political origin or independence; the second date (if any) identifies when its current borders were established*

*The area figure denotes total land area*



# Afghanistan

About 75% of this landlocked Asian country is inaccessible. The Islamist *Taliban*, ousted in 2001, continue to fight a guerrilla war against Afghan and NATO-led forces.



## GEOGRAPHY

Predominantly mountainous. Highest range is the Hindu Kush. Mountains are bordered by fertile plains. Desert plateau in the south.



## CLIMATE

Harsh continental. Hot, dry summers. Cold winters with heavy snow, especially in the Hindu Kush.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

*Mujahideen* factions fought first against Soviet invaders (from 1979), and then against each other (after 1989), before the *Taliban* won control in 1996. Under their strict Islamist regime women were denied all rights and ethnic tensions were exacerbated. The US assisted anti-*Taliban* forces in 2001 as part of its “war on terrorism.” A new democratic government struggles to maintain control as insurgency continues.



## THE ECONOMY

Mainly agricultural, severely disrupted by war. Illicit opium trade is big cash earner. Natural gas pipeline planned from the Caspian Sea to Pakistan.



**INSIGHT:** *The UN estimates that it could take 100 years to remove the 10 million landmines laid since 1979*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Islamic State of Afghanistan

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1919

**CAPITAL:** Kabul

**POPULATION:** 28.1 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 250,000 sq. miles (647,500 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 112 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Pashtu\*, Dari\*, Tajik, other

**RELIGIONS:** Sunni Muslim 84%, Shi'a Muslim 15%, other 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Pashtun 38%, Tajik 25%, Hazara 19%, Uzbek, Turkmen, other 18%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Afghan = 100 pul

# Albania



Lying at the southeastern end of the Adriatic Sea, Albania was the last east European country to liberalize its economy. The regional strife of the 1990s has left a difficult legacy.



## GEOGRAPHY

Narrow coastal plain. Interior is mostly hills and mountains. Forest and scrub cover over 40% of the land.



## CLIMATE

Mediterranean coastal climate, with warm summers and cool winters. Mountains receive heavy rains or snows in winter.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The pace of economic reform remains a major issue. EU membership, applied for in 2009, is a distant prospect. Mosques and churches have reopened in what was once the world's only officially atheist state. The Greek minority in the south suffers much discrimination.



**INSIGHT:** *The Albanians' name for their country, Shqipërisë, means "Land of the Eagles"*



## THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas reserves have potential to offset rudimentary infrastructure and lack of foreign investment. Organized crime problem.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Albania

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1912

**CAPITAL:** Tirana

**POPULATION:** 3.16 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 11,100 sq. miles  
(28,748 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 298 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Albanian\*, Greek

**RELIGIONS:** Sunni Muslim 70%,  
Orthodox Christian 20%,  
Roman Catholic 10%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Albanian 93%, Greek 5%,  
other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Lek = 100 qindarka (qintars)



# Algeria



Africa's second-largest country, Algeria won independence from France in 1962. Today, national reconciliation is key to recovery from a conflict launched by Islamic extremists in 1992.



## GEOGRAPHY

85% of the country lies within the Sahara Desert. Fertile coastal region with plains and hills rises from the southeast to the Atlas Mountains.



## CLIMATE

Coastal areas are warm and temperate, with most rainfall during the mild winters. The south is very hot, with negligible rainfall.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Algerians are predominantly Arab, under 30 years of age, and urban. Most indigenous Berbers consider the mountainous Kabylia region in the northeast to be their homeland. They have been granted greater ethnic rights in recent years. The Sahara sustains just 500,000 people, mainly oil workers and Tuareg nomads with goat and camel herds, who move between the irrigated oases.

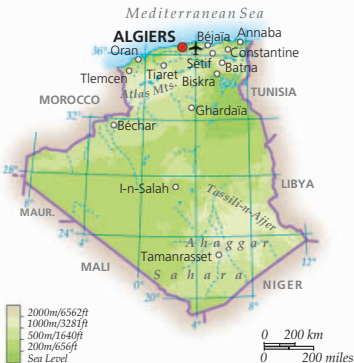


## THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas exports. Political turmoil has led to exodus of skilled foreign labor. Limited agriculture.



**INSIGHT:** *The world's highest dunes are located in the deserts of east central Algeria*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** People's Democratic Republic of Algeria

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1962

**CAPITAL:** Algiers

**POPULATION:** 34.9 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 919,590 sq. miles  
(2,381,740 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 38 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Arabic\*, Tamazight, French

**RELIGIONS:** Sunni Muslim 99%,  
Christian and Jewish 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Arab 75%, Berber 24%,  
European and Jewish 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Algerian dinar = 100 centimes

# Andorra



A tiny landlocked principality, Andorra lies high in the eastern Pyrenees between France and Spain. It held its first full elections in 1993. Tourism is the main source of income.



## GEOGRAPHY

High mountains, with six deep, glaciated valleys that drain into the Valira River as it flows into Spain.



## CLIMATE

Cool, wet springs followed by dry, warm summers. Mountain snows linger until March.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Immigration is strictly monitored and restricted by quota to French and Spanish nationals seeking employment in Andorra. Low taxes attract wealthy expatriates. A referendum in 1993 ended 715 years of semifeudal status, but Andorran society remains conservative.



**INSIGHT:** *Andorra's coprincipality status dates from the 13th century. The "princes" are the president of France and the bishop of Urgel in Spain.*



## THE ECONOMY

Tourism and duty-free sales dominate the economy. Banking secrecy laws and low consumer taxes promote investment and commerce. France and Spain effectively decide economic policy. Dependence on imported food and raw materials.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Principality of Andorra

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1278

**CAPITAL:** Andorra la Vella

**POPULATION:** 82,200

**TOTAL AREA:** 181 sq. miles  
(468 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 457 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish, Catalan\*, French, Portuguese

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 94%, other 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Spanish 46%, Andorran 28%, other 18%, French 8%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Euro = 100 cents



# Angola

Located in southwest Africa, Angola suffered a civil war following independence from Portugal in 1975, until a 2002 peace deal. Hundreds of thousands of people died.



## GEOGRAPHY

Most of the land is hilly and grass-covered. Desert in the south. Mountains in the center and north.



## CLIMATE

Varies from temperate to tropical. Rainfall decreases north to south. Coast is cooler and dry.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Civil war pitched the ruling Kimbundu-dominated MPLA against UNITA, representing the Ovimbundu. Multiparty elections in 1991–1992, after the MPLA had abandoned Marxism, failed to stall the war for long. Power-sharing from 2002 ended when the MPLA won the 2008 election; a presidential poll has yet to be held.



**INSIGHT:** Angola has the greatest number of amputees (caused by landmines) in the world



## THE ECONOMY

Potentially one of Africa's richest countries, but long civil war hampered economic development. Oil and diamonds are exported.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Angola

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1975

**CAPITAL:** Luanda

**POPULATION:** 18.5 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 481,351 sq. miles  
(1,246,700 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 38 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Portuguese\*, Umbundu, Kimbundu, Kikongo

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 50%, other 30%, Protestant 20%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Ovimbundu 37%, other 25%, Kimbundu 25%, Bakongo 13%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Readjusted kwanza = 100 lwei

# Antarctica



The circumpolar continent of Antarctica is almost entirely covered by ice, some up to 1.2 miles (2 km) thick. It also contains 90% of the Earth's freshwater reserves.



## GEOGRAPHY

The bulk of Antarctica's ice is contained in the Greater Antarctic Ice Sheet – a huge dome that rises steeply from the coast and flattens to a plateau in the interior.



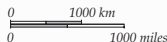
## CLIMATE

Powerful winds create a storm belt around the continent, which brings cloud, fog, and blizzards. Winter temperatures can fall to  $-112^{\circ}\text{F}$  ( $-80^{\circ}\text{C}$ ).

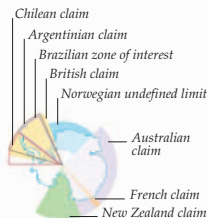


## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

No indigenous population. Scientists and logistical staff work at the 40 permanent, and as many as 100 temporary, research stations. A few Chilean settler families live on King George Island. Tourism is mostly by cruise ship to the Antarctic Peninsula. Annual tourist numbers have reached nearly 50,000.



### Territorial Claims:



The Antarctic Treaty of 1959 holds all territorial claims in abeyance in the interest of international cooperation



## FACTFILE

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1961

**TOTAL AREA:** 5,405,000 sq. miles  
(14,000,000 sq. km)



**INSIGHT:** If the ice sheets of Antarctica were to melt, the world's oceans would rise by as much as 200–210 ft (60–65 m)



# Antigua & Barbuda

A former colony of Spain, France, and the UK, Antigua and Barbuda lies at the outer edge of the Leeward Islands group in the Caribbean, and includes the uninhabited islet of Redonda.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mainly low-lying limestone and coral islands with some higher volcanic areas. Antigua's coast is indented with bays and harbors.



## CLIMATE

Tropical, moderated by trade winds and sea breezes. Humidity and rainfall are low for the region.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Population almost entirely of African origin, with small communities of Europeans and South Asians. Women's status has risen as a result of greater access to education. Wealth disparities are small. The Bird family dominated politics from 1960, but lost power to the United Progressive Party (UPP) from 2004.



**INSIGHT:** In 1865, Redonda was "claimed" by an eccentric Englishman as a kingdom for his son



## THE ECONOMY

Tourism is the main source of revenue and the biggest provider of jobs. Financial services and Internet gambling are expanding. High debt.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Antigua and Barbuda

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1981

**CAPITAL:** St. John's

**POPULATION:** 82,800

**TOTAL AREA:** 170 sq. miles  
(442 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 487 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** English\*, English patois

**RELIGIONS:** Anglican 45%,  
other Protestant 42%, Roman Catholic 10%,  
other 2%, Rastafarian 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Black African 95%,  
other 5%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** E. Caribbean \$ = 100 cents

# Argentina



Argentina occupies most of southern South America. After 30 years of intermittent military rule, democracy returned in 1983. Economy has slowed since its recovery from 2001 crash.



## GEOGRAPHY

The Andes form a natural border with Chile in the west. East are the heavily wooded plains (Gran Chaco) and treeless but fertile Pampas plains. Bleak and arid Patagonia in the south.



## CLIMATE

The Andes are semiarid in the north and snowy in the south. Pampas have a mild climate with summer rains.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

People are largely of European descent; over one-third are of Italian origin. Indigenous peoples are now in a minority, living mainly in Andean regions or in the Gran Chaco. The middle classes were worst hit by the economic meltdown of 2001–2002.



**INSIGHT:** *The Tango originated in the poorer quarters of Buenos Aires at the end of the 19th century*



## THE ECONOMY

Agricultural exports restored growth from 2003, but bad drought in 2008 coincided with global downturn.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Argentina

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1816

**CAPITAL:** Buenos Aires

**POPULATION:** 40.3 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 1,068,296 sq. miles  
(2,766,890 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 38 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish\*, Italian, Amerindian languages

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 90%, other 6%, Protestant 2%, Jewish 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Indo-European 83%, Mestizo 14%, Jewish 2%, Amerindian 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Argentine peso = 100 centavos



# Armenia



The smallest of the former USSR's republics, Armenia lies landlocked in the Lesser Caucasus Mountains. After 1988, a confrontation with Azerbaijan dominated national life.



## GEOGRAPHY

Rugged and mountainous, with expanses of semidesert and a large lake in the east: Sevana Lich.



## CLIMATE

Continental climate, with little rainfall in the lowlands. The winters are often bitterly cold.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Christianity is the dominant religion, but minority groups are well integrated. War with Azerbaijan over the enclave of Nagorno Karabakh forced 350,000 Armenians living in Azerbaijan to return home, many to live in poverty. There are close and important ties to the seven-million-strong Armenian diaspora.



**INSIGHT:** *In the 4th century, Armenia became the first country to adopt Christianity as its state religion*



## THE ECONOMY

Overseas remittances and agriculture each account for a sixth of GDP. Main products are wine, tobacco, potatoes, and fruit. Well-developed machine-building and manufacturing – includes textiles and bottling of mineral water.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Armenia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1991

**CAPITAL:** Yerevan

**POPULATION:** 3.08 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 11,506 sq. miles  
(29,800 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 268 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Armenian\*, Azeri, Russian

**RELIGIONS:** Armenian Apostolic Church (Orthodox) 88%, Armenian Catholic Church 6%, other 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Armenian 98%, Yezidi 1%, other 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Dram = 100 luma

# Australia



An island continent in its own right, Australia is the world's sixth-largest country. European settlement began over 200 years ago. Most Australians now live in cities along the coast.



## GEOGRAPHY

Located between the Indian and Pacific oceans, Australia has a variety of landscapes, including tropical rainforests, the arid plateaus, ridges, and vast deserts of the "red center," the lowlands and river systems draining into Lake Eyre, rolling tracts of pastoral land, and magnificent beaches around much of the coastline. In the far east are the mountains of the Great Dividing Range. Famous natural features include Uluru (Ayers Rock) and the Great Barrier Reef.



## CLIMATE

The west and south are semi-arid with hot summers. The arid interior can reach 120°F (50°C) in the central desert areas. The north is hot throughout the year, and humid during the summer monsoon. East, southeast, and southwest coastal areas are temperate.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The first settlers arrived in Australia at least 100,000 years ago. Today, the Aborigines make up around 2% of the population. European colonization began in 1788, and was dominated by British and Irish immigrants, some of whom were convicts. White-only immigration drives brought many Europeans to Australia, but since the 1960s multi-culturalism has been encouraged and most new settlers are Asian; Cantonese has overtaken Italian as the second most widely spoken language. Wealth disparities are small, but Aborigines, the exception in an otherwise integrated society, are marginalized: their average life expectancy is around 11 years less than other Australians. The new Labor government from 2007 has overturned right-wing policies on illegal immigration and has signed up to limiting greenhouse gas emissions.

## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Commonwealth of Australia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1901

**CAPITAL:** Canberra

**POPULATION:** 21.3 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 2,967,893 sq. miles  
(7,686,850 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 7 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** English\*, Cantonese, other

**RELIGIONS:** Various Protestant 38%, other 36%, Roman Catholic 26%

**ETHNIC MIX:** European 90%, Asian 7%, Aboriginal 2%, other 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Australian dollar = 100 cents

## THE ECONOMY

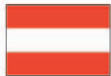
Efficient mining and agriculture: particular success in viticulture. Large resource base: coal, iron ore, bauxite, and most other minerals. Protectionism abandoned to open up Australian markets. Concentration on trade with Asia: China's expanding demand for minerals spurred a return to strong economic growth after the 1997

Asian financial crisis. China now rivals Japan as Australia's major trading partner. Upward trend in Asian visitor arrivals has strengthened tourism.

 **INSIGHT:** *Sydney has the world's largest suburban area, a conurbation so vast that the city is twice as large as Beijing and six times the size of Rome*



# Austria



Bordering eight countries in the heart of Europe, Austria was created in 1918 after the collapse of the Habsburg Empire. Neutral after World War II, it joined the EU in 1995.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mainly mountainous. Alps and foothills cover the west and south. Lowlands in the east are part of the Danube River basin.



## CLIMATE

Temperate continental climate. The western Alpine regions have colder winters and more rainfall.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Though Austrians speak German, they like to stress their distinctive identity in relation to Germany. Vienna is a major cultural center. Minorities are few; there are some ethnic Croats, Slovenes, and Hungarians, plus refugees from conflict in former Yugoslavia. Though strongly Roman Catholic, Austrian society is less conservative than some southern German *Länder*. Class divisions remain strong.



## THE ECONOMY

Large manufacturing base, despite lack of energy resources. The skilled labor force is key to high-tech exports. Eurozone membership since 2002 has boosted investment.



**INSIGHT:** Many of the world's great composers were Austrian, including Mozart, Haydn, Schubert, and Strauss



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Austria

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1918

**CAPITAL:** Vienna

**POPULATION:** 8.36 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 32,378 sq. miles  
(83,858 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 262 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** German\*, Croatian, Slovenian, Hungarian (Magyar)

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 78%, nonreligious 9%, other 8%, Protestant 5%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Austrian 93%, Croat, Slovene, and Hungarian 6%, other 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Euro = 100 cents



# Azerbaijan



Situated on the western coast of the Caspian Sea, it was the first Soviet republic to declare independence in 1991.

Territorial disputes with Armenia have dominated politics since.



## GEOGRAPHY

Caucasus Mountains in west, including Naxçıvan exclave south of Armenia. Flat, low-lying terrain on the coast of the Caspian Sea.



## CLIMATE

Low rainfall. Continental, with bitter winters, inland. Subtropical in coastal regions.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Azeris, a Muslim people with ethnic links to Turks, form a large majority. Thousands of Armenians, Russians, and Jews have left since independence. Influx of half a million Azeri refugees fleeing war with Armenia over the disputed enclave of Nagorno-Karabakh. Armenians there operate with de facto independence. The status of women deteriorated after the fall of communism but they are slowly regaining their position.



## THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas exports drive economic growth. Pipeline to Ceyhan, Turkey, has opened up European market. Severe pollution in Baku.



**INSIGHT:** *The fire-worshipping Zoroastrian faith originated in Azerbaijan in the 6th century BCE*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Azerbaijan

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1991

**CAPITAL:** Baku

**POPULATION:** 8.83 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 33,436 sq. miles  
(86,600 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 264 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Azeri\*, Russian

**RELIGIONS:** Shi'a Muslim 68%,  
Sunni Muslim 26%, Russian Orthodox 3%,  
Armenian Orthodox 2%, other 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Azeri 91%, other 3%,  
Lazs 2%, Russian 2%, Armenian 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** New manat = 100 gopik

# Bahamas



Located off the Florida coast in the western Atlantic, the Bahamas comprises an archipelago of some 700 islands and 2400 cays, only around 30 of which are inhabited.



## GEOGRAPHY

Long, mainly flat coral formations with a few low hills. Some islands have pine forests, lagoons, and mangrove swamps.



## CLIMATE

Subtropical. Hot summers and mild winters. Heavy rainfall, especially in summer. Hurricanes can strike in July–December.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Over 60% of the population live on New Providence. Tourism employs over 40% of the labor force. There are marked wealth disparities, from urban professionals in the banking sector to traditional fishermen on outlying islands and illegal Haitian and Cuban immigrants. More women are now entering the professions. Government priorities are tackling narcotics trafficking and money laundering.



## THE ECONOMY

Major tourist destination, especially for US visitors. Financial services: banking and insurance.



**INSIGHT:** The country's extensive merchant fleet consists mainly of "flag-of-convenience" vessels registered by foreign owners



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Commonwealth of the Bahamas

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1973

**CAPITAL:** Nassau

**POPULATION:** 341,700

**TOTAL AREA:** 5382 sq. miles  
(13,940 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 88 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** English\*, English Creole, French Creole

**RELIGIONS:** Baptist 32%, other 29%, Anglican 20%, Roman Catholic 19%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Black African 85%, other 15%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Bahamian dollar = 100 cents



# Bahrain

Bahrain is an archipelago of 49 islands between the Qatar peninsula and the Saudi Arabian mainland. Only three of the islands are inhabited. It was the first Gulf emirate to export oil.



## GEOGRAPHY

All islands are low-lying. The largest, Bahrain Island, is mainly sandy plains and salt marshes.



## CLIMATE

Summers are hot and humid. Winters are mild. Low rainfall.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The key social division is between the Shi'a majority and Sunni minority. Sunnis hold the best jobs in bureaucracy and business while Shi'as tend to do menial work. The al-Khalifa family has ruled since 1783, but transformed Bahrain into a constitutional monarchy, with limited democracy, in 2002. Bahrain is socially liberal.

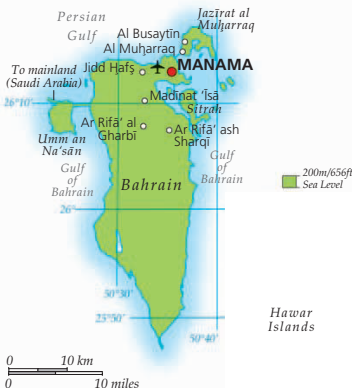


**INSIGHT:** The 16 Hawar Islands were awarded to Bahrain in 2001 after a lengthy dispute with Qatar



## THE ECONOMY

Main exports are refined petroleum and aluminum products. As oil reserves run out, natural gas is of increasing importance. Major Middle East offshore banking center, hit by global banking crisis in 2008–2009.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Kingdom of Bahrain

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1971

**CAPITAL:** Manama

**POPULATION:** 791,500

**TOTAL AREA:** 239 sq. miles  
(620 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 2899 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Arabic\*

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim (mainly Shi'a) 99%,  
other 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Bahraini 70%, Iranian,  
Indian, and Pakistani 24%, other 6%

**GOVERNMENT:** Mixed monarchical-  
parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Bahraini dinar = 1000 fils

# Bangladesh



Bangladesh lies at the north end of the Bay of Bengal and frequently suffers devastating flood, cyclones, and famine. It seceded from Pakistan in 1971.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mostly flat alluvial plains and deltas of the Brahmaputra and Ganges rivers. Southeast coasts are fringed with mangrove forests.



## CLIMATE

Hot and humid. During the monsoon, water levels can rise 20 ft (6 m) above sea level.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

After a period of military rule, Bangladesh returned to democracy in 1991; political instability has continued, however, and corruption is a major problem. Half of the population live in poverty, but living standards are improving. Women are prominent in politics, but their rights are neglected.



**INSIGHT:** *Torrential monsoon rains flood two-thirds of the country every year*



## THE ECONOMY

Agriculture is vulnerable to unpredictable climate. Bangladesh accounts for 90% of world jute fiber exports. Poor infrastructure deters investment. Growing textile industry.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** People's Republic of Bangladesh

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1971

**CAPITAL:** Dhaka

**POPULATION:** 162 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 55,598 sq. miles  
(144,000 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 3138 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Bengali\*, Urdu, Chakma, Marma, Garo, Khasi, Santhali, Tripuri, Mro

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim (mainly Sunni) 87%, Hindu 12%, other 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Bengali 98%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Taka = 100 poisha



# Barbados



Barbados is the most easterly of the Caribbean islands. Once solely inhabited by the native Arawak, Barbados was first colonized by British settlers in the 1620s.



## GEOGRAPHY

Encircled by coral reefs. Fertile and predominantly flat, with a few gentle hills to the north.



## CLIMATE

Moderate tropical climate. Sunnier and drier than its more mountainous neighbors.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Some latent tension between white community, which controls politics and much of the economy, and majority black population, but violence is rare. Increasing social mobility has enabled black Barbadians to enter the professions. Despite political stability, and good welfare and education services, pockets of abject poverty remain.



**INSIGHT:** Barbados retains a strong British influence and is referred to by its neighbors as "Little England"



## THE ECONOMY

Well-developed tourism sector based on climate and accessibility. Financial services, offshore banking, and information processing are key industries. Sugar production has dwindled. High cost of living.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Barbados

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1966

**CAPITAL:** Bridgetown

**POPULATION:** 255,900

**TOTAL AREA:** 166 sq. miles  
(430 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 1542 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Bajan (Barbadian English), English\*

**RELIGIONS:** Anglican 40%, other 24%, nonreligious 17%, Pentecostal 8%, Methodist 7%, Roman Catholic 4%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Black African 92%, other 8%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Barbados dollar = 100 cents

# Belarus



Literally "White Russia," Belarus lies landlocked in eastern Europe. It reluctantly became independent when the USSR broke up in 1991. It has few resources other than agriculture.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mainly plains and low hills. The Dnieper and Dvina rivers drain the eastern lowlands. Vast Pripyet Marshes in the southwest.



## CLIMATE

Extreme continental climate. Winters are long, sub-freezing, but mainly dry; summers are hot.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Only 2% of people are non-Slav, so ethnic tension is minimal. Russian culture dominates. Belarus was the slowest ex-Soviet state to implement political reform; President Lukashenko has been labeled as Europe's last dictator. Enthusiasm for a merger with Russia has waned. Wealth is held by a small ex-Communist elite. Fallout from the 1986 Chernobyl nuclear disaster in Ukraine still seriously affects health and the environment.



## THE ECONOMY

Low unemployment. Industry outmoded and mainly state-owned. Depends on Russia for energy and raw materials; tensions over natural gas prices.



**INSIGHT:** *The number of cancer and leukemia cases soared after the 1986 Chernobyl disaster*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Belarus

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1991

**CAPITAL:** Minsk

**POPULATION:** 9.63 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 80,154 sq. miles  
(207,600 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 120 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Belarussian\*, Russian\*

**RELIGIONS:** Orthodox Christian 60%, other (including Muslim, Jewish, and Protestant) 32%, Roman Catholic 8%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Belarussian 81%, Russian 11%, Polish 4%, Ukrainian 2%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Belarussian rouble = 100 kopeks



# Belgium



Belgium lies in northwestern Europe. Its history has been marked by tensions between the majority Dutch-speaking (Flemish) and minority French-speaking (Walloon) communities.



## GEOGRAPHY

Low-lying coastal plain covers two-thirds of the country. Land becomes hilly and forested in the southeast (Ardennes) region.



## CLIMATE

Maritime climate with Gulf Stream influences. Temperatures are mild, with heavy cloud cover and rain. More rainfall and weather fluctuations at the coast.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Since 1970, Flemish regions have become more prosperous than those of the minority Walloons, overturning traditional roles and increasing friction. Belgium moved to a federal system from 1980 in order to contain tensions, but recent fractious politics have raised doubts over the union's survival. Brussels hosts key European Union institutions.



## THE ECONOMY

Variety of industrial exports, including steel, glassware, cut diamonds, and textiles. Very high levels of public debt. Bureaucracy larger than European average.



**INSIGHT:** *The Ardennes region, in the southeast of the country, is famous for its forests, lakes, and cuisine*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Kingdom of Belgium

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1830

**CAPITAL:** Brussels

**POPULATION:** 10.6 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 11,780 sq. miles  
(30,510 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 840 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Dutch\*, French\*, German\*

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 88%, other 10%, Muslim 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Flemish 58%, Walloon 33%, other 6%, Italian 2%, Moroccan 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Euro = 100 cents

# Belize



Belize lies on the eastern shore of the Yucatan Peninsula. Formerly called British Honduras, Belize was the last Central American country to gain its independence, in 1981.



## GEOGRAPHY

Almost half the land area is forested. Low mountains in southeast. Flat swampy coastal plains.



## CLIMATE

Tropical. Very hot and humid, with May–December rainy season.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

English-speaking black Creoles are outnumbered by Spanish speakers, including native *mestizos* and immigrants from neighboring states. The Creoles have traditionally dominated society, but high levels of emigration to the US have weakened their influence. The Afro-Carib *garifuna* have their own language. Corruption, and trafficking of people and narcotics, are major problems.



**INSIGHT:** Belize's barrier reef is the second-largest in the world



## THE ECONOMY

Tourism, agriculture, and offshore banking. Oil extraction began in 2005. Sugar, textiles, lobsters, and shrimp are exported. Serious hurricane damage is a recurring problem.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Belize

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1981

**CAPITAL:** Belmopan

**POPULATION:** 306,800

**TOTAL AREA:** 8867 sq. miles  
(22,966 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 35 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** English Creole, Spanish, English\*, Mayan, Garifuna (Carib)

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 62%, other 20%, Anglican 12%, Methodist 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mestizo 49%, Creole 25%, Maya 11%, other 9%, Garifuna 6%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Belizean dollar = 100 cents



# Benin



Benin stretches north from the west African coast. In 1990, Benin became one of the pioneers of African democratization, ending 17 years of one-party Marxist-Leninist rule.



## GEOGRAPHY

Sandy coastal region. Numerous lagoons lie just behind the shoreline. Forested plateaus inland. Mountains in the northwest.



## CLIMATE

Hot and humid in the south. Two rainy seasons. Hot, dusty *harmattan* winds blow during the December–February dry season.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

There are 42 different ethnic groups. The southern Fon have tended to dominate politics. Other major groups are the Adja and Yoruba. The northern Fulani follow a nomadic lifestyle. North–south tension is mainly due to the south being more developed. French culture, centered on Cotonou, is highly prized. Substantial differences in wealth reflect a strongly hierarchical society.



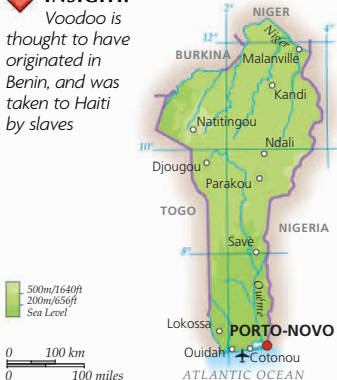
## THE ECONOMY

Strong agricultural sector: cash crops include cotton, oil palm, and cashew nuts. Large-scale smuggling is a serious problem. France is the main aid donor.



## INSIGHT:

*Voodoo is thought to have originated in Benin, and was taken to Haiti by slaves*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Benin

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1960

**CAPITAL:** Porto-Novo

**POPULATION:** 8.94 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 43,483 sq. miles  
(112,620 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 209 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Fon, Bariba, Yoruba, Adja, Houeda, Somba, French\*

**RELIGIONS:** 50%, Muslim 30%, Christian 20%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Fon 41%, other 21%, Adja 16%, Yoruba 12%, Bariba 10%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes

# Bhutan



Perched in the eastern Himalayas between India and China lies the landlocked Kingdom of Bhutan. It is largely closed to the outside world to protect its culture; TV was banned until 1999.



## GEOGRAPHY

Low, tropical southern strip rising through fertile central valleys to high Himalayas in the north. Around 70% of the land is forested.



## CLIMATE

South is tropical, north is alpine, cold, and harsh. Central valleys warmer in east than west.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The king was absolute monarch until 1998, and the first democratic elections were held a decade later. Most people are devoutly Buddhist and originate from Tibet. The Hindu Nepalese settled in the south. Bhutan has 20 languages. In 1988, Dzongkha (a Tibetan dialect native to just 16% of the people) was made the official language. The Nepalese community regard this as "cultural imperialism," causing considerable ethnic tensions.



## THE ECONOMY

Reliant on India for trade. Most people farm their own plots of land and herd cattle and yaks. Steep land unsuited for cultivation. Development of cash crops for Asian markets.



**INSIGHT:** In 2004 Bhutan became the first country in the world to ban smoking and the sale of tobacco



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Kingdom of Bhutan

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1656

**CAPITAL:** Thimphu

**POPULATION:** 697,300

**TOTAL AREA:** 18,147 sq. miles  
(47,000 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 38 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Dzongkha\*, Nepali

**RELIGIONS:** Mahayana Buddhist 70%,  
Hindu 24%, other 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Bhute 50%, other 25%,  
Nepalese 25%

**GOVERNMENT:** Mixed monarchical–  
parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Ngultrum = 100 chetrum



# Bolivia

Landlocked high in central South America, Bolivia is one of the region's poorest countries. La Paz is the world's highest capital city: 13,385 feet (3631 m) above sea level.



## GEOGRAPHY

A high windswept plateau, the *altiplano*, lies between two Andean mountain ranges. Semiarid grasslands to the east; dense tropical forests to the north.



## CLIMATE

*Altiplano* has extreme tropical climate, with night-frost in winter. North and east are hot and humid.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The indigenous majority faces widespread discrimination. Wealthy Spanish-descended families have traditionally controlled the economy. Amerindian Evo Morales, president from 2005, pledged to cut poverty, legalize coca, and redistribute land.



## INSIGHT: Between 1825 and 1982

Bolivia averaged more than one armed coup a year



## THE ECONOMY

Gold, silver, zinc, tin, oil, natural gas: all vulnerable to world price fluctuations. Social issues and nationalization of natural gas sector deter investors. Major coca producer. Lack of manufacturing. Rich eastern provinces want autonomy.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Bolivia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1825

**CAPITAL:** La Paz (administrative);

Sucre (judicial)

**POPULATION:** 9.86 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 424,162 sq. miles

(1,098,580 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 24 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Aymara\*, Quechua\*, Spanish\*

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 93%,  
other 7%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Quechua 37%, Aymara 32%,  
mixed 13%, European 10%, other 8%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Boliviano = 100 centavos

# Bosnia & Herzegovina



Perched in the highlands of southeast Europe, Bosnia and Herzegovina was the focus of the bitter ethnic conflict which accompanied the early 1990s dissolution of the Yugoslav state.



## GEOGRAPHY

Hills and mountains, with narrow river valleys. Lowlands in the north. Mainly deciduous forest covers about half of the total area.



## CLIMATE

Continental. Hot summers and cold, often snowy winters.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Despite sharing the same origin and spoken language, Bosnians have been divided by history between Orthodox Serbs, Catholic Croats, and Muslim Bosniaks. Ethnic cleansing was practiced by all sides in the civil war, displacing about 60% of the population. Hopes for EU integration will require further ethnic reconciliation.



**INSIGHT:** *The murder of Archduke Ferdinand of Austria in Sarajevo in 1914 triggered the First World War*



## THE ECONOMY

Potential to recover status as a thriving market economy with a strong manufacturing base, but still struggles with resettling refugees and the legacy of war. Little investment.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Bosnia and Herzegovina

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1992

**CAPITAL:** Sarajevo

**POPULATION:** 3.77 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 19,741 sq. miles  
(51,129 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 191 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Bosnian\*, Serbian\*, Croatian\*

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim 40%, Orthodox Christian 31%, Catholic 15%, other 14%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Bosniak 44%, Serb 31%, Croat 17%, other 8%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Marka = 100 pfeninga



# Botswana

Landlocked in the heart of southern Africa, Botswana boasts the world's largest inland river delta. Diamonds provide potential wealth, but the country is crippled by HIV/AIDS.



## GEOGRAPHY

Lies on vast plateau, high above sea level. Hills in the east. Kalahari Desert in center and southwest. Swamps and salt pans elsewhere and in Okavango Basin.



## CLIMATE

Dry and prone to drought. Summer wet season, April–October. Winters are warm, with cold nights.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The nomadic San bushmen, the first inhabitants, are marginalized. One in four adults are living with HIV/AIDS; only Swaziland is worse affected. Life expectancy is around 50 years. Diamond revenue has widened wealth inequalities.



**INSIGHT:** *Water, Botswana's most precious resource, is honored in the name of the currency – pula*



## THE ECONOMY

Overreliance on diamonds: vulnerable to world price fluctuations. Beef is exported to Europe. Tourism aimed at wealthy wildlife enthusiasts. AIDS is devastating the population.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Botswana

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1966

**CAPITAL:** Gaborone

**POPULATION:** 1.95 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 231,803 sq. miles  
(600,370 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 9 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Setswana, English\*, Shona, San, Khoikhoi, isiNdebele

**RELIGIONS:** Traditional beliefs 50%, Christian (mainly Protestant) 30%, other (including Muslim) 20%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Tswana 98%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Pula = 100 thebe

# Brazil



Covering almost half of South America, Brazil is the site of the world's largest and ecologically most important rainforest. The country has immense natural and economic resources.



## GEOGRAPHY

Rainforest grows around the massive Amazon River and its delta, covering almost half of Brazil's total land area. Apart from the basin of the River Plate to the south, the rest of the country consists of highlands. The mountainous east is part-forested and part-desert. The coastal plain in the southeast has swampy areas. The Atlantic coastline is 1240 miles (2000 km) long.



## CLIMATE

Brazil's share of the Amazon Basin has a model tropical equatorial climate, with high temperatures and rainfall all year round. The Brazilian plateau has far greater seasonal variation. The dry northeast suffers frequent droughts, though coastal regions are occasionally flooded by bouts of torrential rain. The south has hot summers and cool winters.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Diverse population includes Amerindians, black people of African descent, European immigrants, and those of mixed race. Amerindians suffer prejudice from most other groups. Shanty towns in the cities attract poor migrants from the northeast. Urban crime, violent land disputes, and unchecked development in Amazonia tarnish Brazil's image as a modern nation. Catholicism and the family unit remain strong.



## THE ECONOMY

Dominant regional economy. Huge potential for growth based on abundant natural resources. A leading exporter of coffee, sugar, and orange juice. Social tension threatens stability. Infrastructure needs investment.

## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Federative Rep. of Brazil

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1822

**CAPITAL:** Brasília

**POPULATION:** 194 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 3,286,470 sq. miles  
(8,511,965 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 59 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Portuguese\*, German, Italian, Spanish, Polish, Japanese, other

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 74%, Protestant 15%, atheist 7%, other 4%

**ETHNIC MIX:** White 54%, Mixed race 38%, Black 6%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Real = 100 centavos

**INSIGHT:** Since 1900, a third of Brazil's indigenous Amerindian groups have become extinct due to disease, starvation, or the forceful taking of land by miners, loggers, and settlers



# Brunei



Lying on the northern coast of the island of Borneo, Brunei is surrounded and divided in two by the Malaysian state of Sarawak. It has been independent since 1984.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mostly dense lowland rainforest and mangrove swamps, with some mountains in the southeast.



## CLIMATE

Tropical. Six-month rainy season with very high humidity.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Malays benefit from positive discrimination. Many in the Chinese community are stateless. Since a failed rebellion in 1962, Brunei has been ruled by decree of the sultan. In 1990, "Malay Muslim Monarchy" was introduced, promoting Islamic values as state ideology. Women, less restricted than in some Muslim states, usually wear headscarves but not the veil.



**INSIGHT:** *The sultan spent US\$350 million building the world's largest palace at Bandar Seri Begawan*



## THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas production has brought one of the world's highest standards of living. Massive overseas investments. Major consumer of high-tech hi-fi, video equipment, and Western designer clothes.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Sultanate of Brunei

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1984

**CAPITAL:** Bandar Seri Begawan

**POPULATION:** 399,700

**TOTAL AREA:** 2228 sq. miles  
(5770 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 196 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Malay\*, English, Chinese

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim (mainly Sunni) 66%, Buddhist 14%, other 10%, Christian 10%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Malay 67%, Chinese 16%, other 11%, indigenous 6%

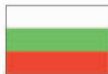
**GOVERNMENT:** Monarchy

**CURRENCY:** Brunei dollar = 100 cents



# Bulgaria

Located in southeastern Europe, Bulgaria was under communist rule from 1947 to 1989. Political and economic reform since then enabled it to join the EU in 2007.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mountains run east–west across center and along southern border. Danube plain in north, Thracian plain in southeast. Black Sea to the east.



## CLIMATE

Warm summers and snowy winters, especially in mountains. East winds bring seasonal extremes.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The communists tried forcibly to suppress cultural identities, leading to a large exodus of Bulgarian Turks in 1989. Later privatization programs left many Turks landless, prompting further emigration. Roma suffer discrimination at all levels of society. Women have equal rights in theory, but society remains patriarchal. EU accession included caveats demanding further action against organized crime, human trafficking, and corruption.



## THE ECONOMY

Good agricultural production, including grapes, for well-developed wine industry, and tobacco. Expertise in software development. Industry and infrastructure are outdated.



**INSIGHT:** *Archaeologists have found evidence of wine-making in Bulgaria dating back over 5000 years*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Bulgaria

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1908

**CAPITAL:** Sofia

**POPULATION:** 7.54 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 42,822 sq. miles  
(110,910 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 177 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Bulgarian\*, Turkish, Romani

**RELIGIONS:** Orthodox Christian 83%, Muslim 12%, other 4%, Catholic 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Bulgarian 84%, Turkish 9%, Roma 5%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Lev = 100 stotinki

# Burkina



The west African state of Burkina was known as Upper Volta until 1984. It became a multiparty state in 1991, though former military ruler Blaise Compaoré remains in power.



## GEOGRAPHY

The Sahara covers the north of the country. The south is largely savanna. The three main rivers are the Black, White, and Red Voltas.



## CLIMATE

Tropical. Dry, cool weather November–February. Erratic rain March–April, mostly in southeast.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

No single ethnic group is dominant, but the Mossi, from around Ouagadougou, have always played an important part in government. The people from the west are much more ethnically mixed. Extreme poverty has led to a strong sense of egalitarianism. Most women are still denied access to education, though their absence from public life belies their real power and social influence.



## THE ECONOMY

Cotton is the major cash crop, but the encroaching Sahara Desert is restricting agriculture. Beneficiary of foreign debt cancellation plans.



**INSIGHT:** Droughts and poor soils mean that many Burkinabes seek work southward in Ghana and Côte d'Ivoire



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Burkina Faso

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1960

**CAPITAL:** Ouagadougou

**POPULATION:** 15.8 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 105,869 sq. miles  
(274,200 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 149 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Mossi, Fulani, French\*, Tuareg, Dyula, Songhai

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim 55%,  
Traditional beliefs 35%, Roman Catholic 9%,  
other Christian 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Other 52%, Mossi 48%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes



# Burundi

Small, densely populated and landlocked, Burundi lies just south of the equator, on the Nile–Congo watershed in central Africa. Its people have the world's lowest per capita income.



## GEOGRAPHY

Hilly with high plateaus in center and savanna in the east. Great Rift Valley on western side.



## CLIMATE

Temperate, with high humidity. Heavy and frequent rainfall, mostly October–May. Highlands have frost.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Burundi has been riven by ethnic conflict between majority Hutu and the Tutsi, who controlled the army – with repeated large-scale massacres: hundreds of thousands of people have died since 1993. The constitution now guarantees an ethnic balance in the government and army. Twa pygmies were not involved in the conflict.



**INSIGHT:** *Burundi's fertility rate is one of the highest in Africa. On average, women have seven children*



## THE ECONOMY

Overwhelmingly agricultural economy, mostly subsistence. Small quantities of gold and tungsten. Potential of oil in Lake Tanganyika. Little prospect of lasting stability.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Burundi

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1962

**CAPITAL:** Bujumbura

**POPULATION:** 8.3 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 10,745 sq. miles  
(27,830 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 838 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Kirundi\*, French\*,  
Kiswahili

**RELIGIONS:** Christian (mainly Roman Catholic)  
60%, traditional beliefs 39%,  
Muslim 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Hutu 85%, Tutsi 14%, Twa 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Burundi franc = 100 centimes

# Cambodia



Located on the Indochinese peninsula in southeast Asia, Cambodia has emerged from genocide, civil war, and invasion from Vietnam. Tourists are returning. Rice is the principal crop.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mostly low-lying basin. Tônlé Sap (Great Lake) drains into the Mekong River. Forested mountains and plateau east of the Mekong.



## CLIMATE

Tropical. High temperatures throughout the year. Heavy rainfall during May–October monsoon.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Devastated by US bombing, then by the Khmer Rouge regime, whose extreme Marxist program killed over a million between 1975 and 1979, Cambodia then endured further civil conflict and Vietnamese occupation. The effects are still felt, reflected in the high rates of orphans, widows, and land-mine victims. A fragile stability has lasted since elections in 1993. King Norodom Sihanouk, a key figure in politics, abdicated in 2004.



## THE ECONOMY

Economy is heavily aid-reliant, still recovering from civil war. Exports rubber and timber. Self-sufficient in rice. Garment industry is growing. Land disputes and corruption issues.



**INSIGHT:** Cambodia has many impressive temples, dating from when the country was the center of the Khmer Empire



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Kingdom of Cambodia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1953

**CAPITAL:** Phnom Penh

**POPULATION:** 14.8 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 69,900 sq. miles  
(181,040 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 217 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Khmer\*, French, Chinese, Vietnamese, Cham

**RELIGIONS:** Buddhist 93%, Muslim 6%, Christian 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Khmer 90%, other 5%, Vietnamese 4%, Chinese 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Riel = 100 sen



# Cameroon



Situated in the corner of the Gulf of Guinea, Cameroon was effectively a one-party state for 30 years. Multiparty elections, since 1992, regularly return that same party to power.



## GEOGRAPHY

Over half the land is forested: equatorial rainforest in north, evergreen forest and wooded savanna in south. Mountains in the west.



## CLIMATE

South is equatorial, with plentiful rainfall, declining inland. Far north is beset by drought.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Around 230 ethnic groups; no single group is dominant. The Bamileke is the largest, though it has never held political power. North-south tensions are diminished by the ethnic diversity. There is more rivalry between majority French- and minority English-speakers.



**INSIGHT:** *Cameroon's name derives from the Portuguese word camarões, after the shrimp fished by the early European explorers*



## THE ECONOMY

Oil reserves. Very diversified agricultural economy – timber, cocoa, bananas, coffee. Fuel smuggling from Nigeria undermines refinery profits. Corruption. Port for Chad and CAR.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Cameroon

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1960

**CAPITAL:** Yaoundé

**POPULATION:** 19.5 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 183,567 sq. miles  
(475,400 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 109 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Bamileke, Fang, Fulani, French\*, English\*

**RELIGIONS:** Catholic 35%, traditional beliefs 25%, Muslim 22%, Protestant 18%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Highlanders 31%, other 39%, equatorial Bantu 19%, Kirdi 11%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes

# Canada



Canada extends from the Arctic to its US border along the 49th parallel. Unified under British rule from 1763, its development and expansion attracted large-scale immigration.



## GEOGRAPHY

The world's second-largest country, stretching north to Cape Colombia on Ellesmere Island, south to Lake Erie, and across five time zones from the Pacific seaboard to Newfoundland. Arctic tundra and islands in the far north give way southward to forests, interspersed with lakes and rivers, and then the vast Canadian Shield, which covers over half the area of Canada. Rocky Mountains in west, beyond which are the Coast Mountains, islands, and fjords. Fertile lowlands in the east.



## CLIMATE

Ranges from polar and subpolar in the north, to continental in the south. Winters in the interior are colder and longer than on the coast, with temperatures well below freezing and deep snow; summers are hotter. Pacific coast has the mildest winters.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Two-thirds of the population live in the Great Lakes–St. Lawrence lowlands, fostering some shared cultural values with the neighboring US. Important differences, however, include wider welfare provision and Commonwealth membership. The French-speaking Québécois wish to preserve their culture and language from further Anglicization, and demand to be recognized as a “distinct society.” The government welcomes ethnic diversity among immigrants, promoting a policy that encourages each group to maintain its own culture. Land claims made by the indigenous peoples are being redressed. Nunavut, an Inuit-governed territory that covers nearly a quarter of Canada's land area, was created from a portion of the Northwest Territories in 1999. Women are well represented at most levels of business and government.

## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Canada

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1867

**CAPITAL:** Ottawa

**POPULATION:** 33.6 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 3,855,171 sq. miles  
(9,984,670 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 9 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** English\*, French\*, other

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 44%, Protestant 29%, other 27%

**ETHNIC ORIGIN:** British, French, and other European 87%, Asian 9%, Amerindian, Métis, and Inuit 4%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Canadian dollar = 100 cents

## THE ECONOMY

Wide-ranging resources, providing exports, cheap energy, and raw materials for manufacturing, underpin a high standard of living, with smaller wealth disparities than in the US. Prices for primary exports fluctuate, but the high oil price has encouraged development of Alberta's vast oil fields. Manufactured exports have flourished under growing global

competition, especially since the creation of the NAFTA free trade area, but reliance on the US market makes the Canadian economy vulnerable to US slowdowns. Unemployment rose during the 2009 recession.

 **INSIGHT:** *The Magnetic North Pole, where the dipping needle of a compass stands still, migrates across northern Canada*



# Cape Verde



Off the west coast of Africa, in the Atlantic Ocean, lies the group of islands that make up Cape Verde, a Portuguese colony until it gained independence in 1975.



## GEOGRAPHY

Ten main islands and eight smaller islets, all of volcanic origin. Mostly mountainous, with steep cliffs and rocky headlands.



## CLIMATE

Warm, and very dry. Subject to droughts that can sometimes last for years at a time.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people are of mixed Portuguese–African origin; the rest are descendants of African slaves or more recent immigrants. Creolization of the culture negates ethnic tensions. Almost half of the population live on Santiago. Around 700,000 Cape Verdeans live abroad, mostly in the US.



**INSIGHT:** Poor soils and lack of surface water mean that Cape Verde is dependent on food aid



## THE ECONOMY

Most people are subsistence farmers. Clothing is the main export. No natural resources. Mid-Atlantic location ensures work maintaining ships and planes.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Cape Verde

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1975

**CAPITAL:** Praia

**POPULATION:** 505,600

**TOTAL AREA:** 1557 sq. miles  
(4033 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 325 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Creole, Portuguese\*

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 97%,  
other 2%, Protestant 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mestiço 60%, African 30%,  
other 10%

**GOVERNMENT:** Mixed presidential-  
parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** C.V. escudo = 100 centavos



# Central African Republic

The Central African Republic (CAR) is a landlocked country lying between the basins of the Chad and Congo Rivers.

Politics has suffered frequent interruption by military coups.



## GEOGRAPHY

Comprises a low plateau, covered by scrub or savanna. North is arid. Equatorial rainforests in the south. The Ubangi River forms the border with the Democratic Republic of the Congo.



## CLIMATE

The south is equatorial; the north is hot and dry. Rain occurs all year round, with heaviest falls between July and October.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Baya and Banda are the largest ethnic groups, but the lingua franca is Sango, a trading creole spoken by the minorities in the south who have traditionally provided most political leaders. Less than 2% of the population live in the north. Recent rebellions by northern groups have displaced thousands of people.



## THE ECONOMY

Dominated by subsistence farming. Exports include diamonds, cotton, timber, and coffee. Aid needed to support refugees. Instability and poor infrastructure hinder progress.



**INSIGHT:** "Emperor" Bokassa's eccentric rule from 1965 to 1979 was followed by military dictatorship until democracy was restored in 1993



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Central African Republic

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1960

**CAPITAL:** Bangui

**POPULATION:** 4.42 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 240,534 sq. miles  
(622,984 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 18 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Sango, Banda, Gbaya, French\*

**RELIGIONS:** Traditional beliefs 60%, Christian 35%, Muslim 5%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Baya 34%, Banda 27%, Mandjia 21%, Sara 10%, other 8%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes

## Chad



Landlocked in north-central Africa, Chad has had a turbulent history since independence from France in 1960. Intermittent periods of civil war followed a military coup in 1975.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Mostly plateaus sloping west-ward to Lake Chad. Northern third is Sahara. Tibesti Mountains in north rise to 10,826 ft (3300 m).

**CLIMATE**

Three distinct zones: desert in north, semiarid region in center, and tropics in south.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

Half the population live in the southern fifth of Chad. The northern third has only 100,000 people, mainly Muslim Touhou nomads. Democracy was restored in 1996 by ex-coup leader Idriss Déby. Instability has continued, first with tension between Muslims and southern Christians and, more recently, with rebellions in the east.



**INSIGHT:** Lake Chad is slowly drying up – it is now estimated to be just 10% of the size it was in 1970

**THE ECONOMY**

The discovery of oil, and the opening of a pipeline to the coast via Cameroon, are transforming Chad's economy, though the new wealth is unlikely to reach most people.

**FACTFILE**

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Chad

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1960

**CAPITAL:** N'djamena

**POPULATION:** 11.2 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 495,752 sq. miles  
(1,284,000 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 23 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** French\*, Sara, Arabic\*, Maba  
**RELIGIONS:** Muslim 55%, traditional beliefs 35%, Christian 10%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Other 30%, Sara 28%, Mayo-Kebbi 12%, Arab 12%, Ouaddai 9%, Kanem-Bornou 9%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes



# Chile

Chile extends in a ribbon down the west coast of South America. It returned to elected civilian rule in 1989 after a referendum forced out military dictator General Pinochet.



## GEOGRAPHY

Fertile valleys in the center between the coast and the Andes. Atacama Desert in north. Deep-sea channels, lakes, and fjords in south.



## CLIMATE

Arid in the north. Hot, dry summers and mild winters in the center. Higher Andean peaks have glaciers and year-round snow. Very wet and stormy in the south.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people are of mixed Spanish–Amerindian descent, and are highly urbanized. Almost a third of the population live in Santiago, many in large slums. There are three main indigenous groups, including the Rapa Nui of Easter Island. General Pinochet's dictatorship was brutally repressive, but the business and middle classes prospered.



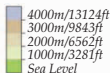
## THE ECONOMY

World's biggest copper producer. Growth in foreign investment due to political stability. Exports include wine, fishmeal, fruits, and salmon.



## INSIGHT:

*Chile's Atacama Desert is the driest place on Earth*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Chile

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1818

**CAPITAL:** Santiago

**POPULATION:** 17 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 292,258 sq. miles  
(756,950 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 59 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish\*, Amerindian languages

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 80%, other and nonreligious 20%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mixed and European 90%, other Amerindian 9%, Mapuche 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Chilean peso = 100 centavos

# China



Covering a vast area of eastern Asia, China is bordered by 14 countries. A one-party Communist state since 1949, it has recently become a dominant force in global manufacturing.



## GEOGRAPHY

A land of huge physical diversity, China has a long Pacific coastline to the east. Two-thirds of the country is uplands. The southwestern mountains include Tibet, the world's highest plateau; in the northwest, the Tien Shan Mountains separate the arid Tarim and Dzungarian basins. The rolling hills and plains of the low-lying east are home to two-thirds of the population.

## CLIMATE



China is divided into two main climatic regions. The north and west are semiarid or arid, with extreme temperature variations. The south and east are warmer and more humid, with year-round rainfall. Winter temperatures vary with latitude, but are warmest on the subtropical southeast coast. Summer temperatures are more uniform, rising above 70°F (21°C).



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people are Han Chinese. The rest of the population belong to one of 55 minority nationalities, or recognized ethnic groups. Many of these groups have a disproportionate political significance as they live in strategic border areas. A policy of resettling Han Chinese in remote regions is deeply resented and has led to uprisings in Xinjiang and Tibet. The government has relaxed the one-child family policy, particularly for minorities, after some small groups were brought close to extinction. Chinese society is patriarchal in practice, and generations tend to live together. However, economic change is breaking down the social controls of the Mao Zedong era. Divorce and unemployment are rising; materialism has replaced the puritanism of the past. A resurgence of religious belief has occurred in recent years.

## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** People's Rep. of China

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 960

**CAPITAL:** Beijing

**POPULATION:** 1.35 billion

**TOTAL AREA:** 3,705,386 sq. miles  
(9,596,960 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 374 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Mandarin\*, other

**RELIGIONS:** Nonreligious 59%, traditional beliefs 20%, other 13%, Buddhist 6%, Muslim 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Han 92%, other 4%, Hui 1%, Miao 1%, Manchu 1%, Zhuang 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** One-party state

**CURRENCY:** Yuan = 10 jiao = 100 fen

## THE ECONOMY

China has shifted from a centrally planned to a market-oriented economy; liberalization has gone furthest in the south where the emerging business class is based. The Tenth Five-Year Plan (2001–2005) emphasized rapid development; the Eleventh Plan aims to reduce wealth disparities. Exports led sustained GDP growth from 2003; China has become the world's third-largest

economy. Faced with a global downturn from 2008, Chinese stimulus packages have boosted domestic spending. The buying power of China's huge market for raw materials and consumer goods could drive global recovery.

 **INSIGHT:** *China has the world's oldest continuous civilization. Its recorded history began 4000 years ago, with the Shang dynasty*



# Colombia



Lying in northwest South America, Colombia has coastlines on both the Caribbean and the Pacific. It is primarily noted for its coffee, emeralds, gold, and cocaine trafficking.



## GEOGRAPHY

The densely forested and almost uninhabited east is separated from the western coastal plains by the Andes, which divide into three ranges (*cordilleras*) with intervening valleys.



## CLIMATE

Coastal plains are hot and wet. The highlands are much cooler. The equatorial east has two wet seasons.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Colombians are of mixed blood. Blacks and Amerindians have the least political representation. Civil conflict over four and a half decades has displaced millions of people, and left over 200,000 dead. The fighting is deeply entwined with the narcotics trade. Violent crime is common.



**INSIGHT:** Over 50% of the world's cocaine is produced in Colombia



## THE ECONOMY

Healthy and diversified export sector – includes coffee and coal. Considerable growth potential, but drugs-related violence and corruption deter foreign investors.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Colombia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1819

**CAPITAL:** Bogotá

**POPULATION:** 45.7 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 439,733 sq. miles  
(1,138,910 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 114 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish\*, Wayuu, Páez, other Amerindian languages

**RELIGIONS:** Catholic 95%, other 5%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mestizo 58%, White 20%, European-African 14%, African 4%, African-Amerindian 3%, other 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Col. peso = 100 centavos



# Comoros

Off the east African coast, between Mozambique and Madagascar, lies the archipelago republic of the Comoros, comprising three main islands and a number of smaller islets.



## GEOGRAPHY

Main islands are of volcanic origin and are heavily forested. The remainder are coral atolls.



## CLIMATE

Hot and humid all year round, especially on the coasts. November to May is hottest and wettest period.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Comoros has absorbed a diversity of people over the years, including Africans, Arabs, Polynesians, and Persians. There have also been Portuguese, Dutch, French, and Indian immigrants. Ethnic discord is rare, but regional tensions between islands are marked. The country is politically unstable and there have been frequent coups. A fragile new federal system has been in place since 2002. Wealth is concentrated within a political and business elite.



## THE ECONOMY

One of the world's poorest countries. Subsistence-level farming. Vanilla and cloves are main cash crops. Lack of basic infrastructure.



**INSIGHT:** *The Comoros is the world's largest producer of ylang-ylang – an extract from tree blossom used in manufacturing perfumes*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Union of the Comoros

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1975

**CAPITAL:** Moroni

**POPULATION:** 676,000

**TOTAL AREA:** 838 sq. miles  
(2170 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 785 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Arabic\*, Comoran\*, French\*

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim (mainly Sunni) 98%, Roman Catholic 1%, other 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Comoran 97%, other 3%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Comoros franc = 100 centimes

# Congo



Astride the equator in west-central Africa, this former French colony emerged from 20 years of Marxist-Leninist rule in 1990. Democracy was soon overshadowed by years of violence.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mostly forest- or savanna-covered plateaus, drained by the Ubangi and Congo river systems. Narrow coastal plain is lined with sand dunes and lagoons.



## CLIMATE

Hot, tropical. Temperatures rarely fall below 86°F (30°C). Two wet and two dry seasons. Rainfall is heaviest south of the equator.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

One of the most tribally conscious and heavily urbanized countries in Africa, with most people living in the Brazzaville–Pointe-Noire region. Main tensions are between the Bakongo in the north and the Mboshi in the south. Relative peace was secured in 1999, and “ninja” rebels in the Pool region, around Brazzaville, signed a peace deal in 2003.



## THE ECONOMY

Oil provides over 95% of export revenue. Timber is extracted. Foreign debt high. Substantial industrial base around Brazzaville and Pointe-Noire.



**INSIGHT:** In 1970, Congo became the first African country to declare itself a communist state



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of the Congo

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1960

**CAPITAL:** Brazzaville

**POPULATION:** 3.68 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 132,046 sq. miles  
(342,000 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 28 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Kongo, Teke, Lingala, French\*

**RELIGIONS:** Traditional 50%, Catholic 25%, Protestant 23%, Muslim 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Bakongo 51%, Teke 17%, other 16%, Mboshi 11%, Mbédé 5%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes



# Congo, (DRC)

Lying in east-central Africa, the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) is one of Africa's largest countries, and the scene of one of its worst regional wars.



## GEOGRAPHY

Rainforested basin of Congo River occupies 60% of the land area. High mountain ranges and lakes stretch down the eastern border.



## CLIMATE

Tropical and humid. Distinct wet and dry seasons south of the equator. The north is mainly wet.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

There are 12 main ethnic groups and around 190 smaller ones. The indigenous forest pygmies, victimized in the war, are now a marginalized group. Civil war from 1996 drew neighboring countries into a bloody conflict. Tentative peace in 2003 was soon undermined by rebels in the east.



**INSIGHT:** The DRC's rainforests comprise 6% of the world's, and 50% of Africa's, remaining woodlands



## THE ECONOMY

Rich resource base: minerals (copper, coltan, cobalt, diamonds) dominate export earnings. War and decades of corruption have caused economic collapse. Food aid is needed to ease humanitarian crisis.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Democratic Republic of the Congo

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1960

**CAPITAL:** Kinshasa

**POPULATION:** 66 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 905,563 sq. miles  
(2,345,410 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 75 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Kiswahili, Tshiluba, French\*

**RELIGIONS:** Christian 70%, Kimbanguist 10%, traditional beliefs 10%, Muslim 10%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Other 55%, Mongo, Luba, Kongo, and Mangbetu-Azande 45%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Congolese franc = 100 centimes

# Costa Rica



Costa Rica, Central America's most stable country, is rich in pristine scenery and exotic wildlife. Its neutrality in foreign affairs is long-standing, but it has strong ties with the US.



## GEOGRAPHY

Coastal plains of swamp and savanna rise to a fertile central plateau, which leads to a mountain range with active volcanic peaks.



## CLIMATE

Hot and humid in coastal regions. Temperate central uplands. High annual rainfall.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people are *mestizo*, of partly Spanish origin. There is a black, English-speaking minority and around 35,000 indigenous Amerindians. Plantation owners are the wealthiest group, while one in six people live in poverty. Nonetheless, living standards are high for the region, and education and healthcare provision is good.



**INSIGHT:** *Costa Rica's 1949 constitution bans a national army*



## THE ECONOMY

Stability has attracted multinationals. The main exports are bananas, pineapples, coffee, and beef, but all are vulnerable to fluctuating world prices. History of high inflation. Pioneer of eco-tourism. Pledged to be carbon neutral by 2021.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Costa Rica

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1838

**CAPITAL:** San José

**POPULATION:** 4.58 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 19,730 sq. miles  
(51,100 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 232 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish\*, English Creole, Bribri, Cabecar

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 76%, other (including Protestant) 24%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mestizo and European 96%, Black 2%, Chinese 1%, Amerindian 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** C.R. colón = 100 céntimos



# Côte d'Ivoire (Ivory Coast)

One of the larger nations along the coast of west Africa,  
Côte d'Ivoire is the world's biggest cocoa producer.  
An image of stability was rocked by civil war in 2002–2005.



## GEOGRAPHY

Sandy coastal strip backed by a largely rainforested interior, and a savanna plateau in the north.



## CLIMATE

High temperatures all year round. South has two wet seasons; north has one, with lower rainfall.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

There are over 60 tribes; the largest is the Baoulé (an Akan group). Southern Christians harbor resentment against non-Ivorian Muslims in the north. Plantations employ millions of migrant workers (including children), though thousands fled back to Burkina during the civil war. Rebels joined a transitional government in 2007.



**INSIGHT:** *The Basilica of Our Lady of Peace in Yamoussoukro is the largest church in the world*



## THE ECONOMY

Main crops are cocoa and coffee. Oil is now major export. Good infrastructure. Lack of professional training. Instability deters investment.



1000m/3281ft  
500m/1640ft  
200m/656ft  
Sea Level

0 100 km  
0 100 miles

## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Côte d'Ivoire

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1960

**CAPITAL:** Yamoussoukro

**POPULATION:** 21.1 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 124,502 sq. miles  
(322,460 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 172 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Akan, French\*, Krou, other

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim 38%, Christian 31%, traditional beliefs 25%, other 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Akan 42%, Voltaïque 18%, Mandé du Nord 17%, Krou 11%, other 12%

**GOVERNMENT:** Transitional regime

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes

# Croatia



Though it was controlled by Hungary from medieval times and was a part of the Yugoslav state for much of the 20th century, Croatia has a very strong national identity.



## GEOGRAPHY

Rocky, mountainous Adriatic coastline is dotted with islands. Interior is a mixture of wooded mountains and broad valleys.



## CLIMATE

The interior has a temperate continental climate. Mediterranean climate along the Adriatic coast.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Croats are distinguished from Bosniaks and Serbs by their Roman Catholic faith and use of the Latin alphabet. Many Serbs fled Croatia during the early 1990s conflict that accompanied Yugoslavia's breakup. Minority rights and fighting organized crime are key issues in the quest for EU membership by 2011.



**INSIGHT:** Croatia only regained control of Serb-occupied Eastern Slavonia, around Vukovar, in 1998



## THE ECONOMY

The war cost the economy an estimated \$50 billion. Unemployment has been persistently high. Corruption deters foreign investment. Tourism is mainly on the Dalmatian coast.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Croatia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1991

**CAPITAL:** Zagreb

**POPULATION:** 4.42 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 21,831 sq. miles  
(56,542 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 202 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Croatian

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 88%,  
other 7%, Orthodox Christian 4%,  
Muslim 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Croat 90%, other 5%,  
Serb 5%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Kuna = 100 lipa



# Cuba

A former Spanish colony, Cuba is the largest island in the Caribbean. It became the only communist country in the Americas after Fidel Castro seized power in 1959.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mostly fertile plains and basins. Three mountainous areas. Forests of pine and mahogany cover one-quarter of the country.



## CLIMATE

Subtropical. Hot all year round, and very hot in summer. Heaviest rainfall in the mountains. Hurricanes can strike in the fall.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Castro regime has reduced formerly extreme wealth disparities, given education a high priority, and established an efficient health service. Political dissent, however, is not tolerated. A dramatic fall in living standards since the late 1980s has led thousands of Cubans to flee to the US, to seek asylum. About 70% of Cubans are of Spanish descent. There is little ethnic tension.



## THE ECONOMY

Sugar industry now superseded by tourism and nickel. US trade embargo, since 1961. Shortages drive a black market. Parallel use of US dollar (1993–2004), and then convertible peso, has boosted investment but created a “dollarized” elite.



**INSIGHT:** *Fidel Castro had become the world's longest-serving non-hereditary ruler before handing power to his brother Raúl in 2006*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Cuba

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1902

**CAPITAL:** Havana

**POPULATION:** 11.2 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 42,803 sq. miles  
(110,860 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 262 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish

**RELIGIONS:** Nonreligious 49%, Roman Catholic 40%, atheist 6%, other 4%, Protestant 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** White 66%, European–African 22%, Black 12%

**GOVERNMENT:** One-party state

**CURRENCY:** Cuban peso = 100 centavos





# Czech Republic

Once part of Czechoslovakia, a central European communist state in 1948–1989, the Czech Republic peacefully dissolved its union with Slovakia in 1993. It joined the EU in 2004.



## GEOGRAPHY

Landlocked in central Europe. Bohemia, the western territory, is a plateau surrounded by mountains. Moravia, in the east, is characterized by hills and lowlands.



## CLIMATE

Cool, sometimes cold winters and warm summer months, which bring most of the annual rainfall.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Secular and urban society, with high divorce rates. Czechs make up the vast majority of the population, while the next largest group are Moravians. The 300,000 Slovaks left after partition are now permitted dual citizenship. Ethnic tensions are few, but there is widespread hostility toward the Roma minority. A new commercial elite is emerging alongside postcommunist entrepreneurs.



## THE ECONOMY

Traditional heavy industries (machinery, iron, car-making) have been successfully privatized. Prague attracts tourists. Skilled workforce. Will join euro in 2013 at earliest.



**INSIGHT:** *Charles University in Prague was founded in the 13th century*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Czech Republic

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1993

**CAPITAL:** Prague

**POPULATION:** 10.4 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 30,450 sq. miles  
(78,866 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 341 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Czech\*, Slovak, Hungarian

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 39%,  
atheist 38%, other 18%, Protestant 3%,  
Hussite 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Czech 90%, other 4%,  
Moravian 4%, Slovak 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Czech koruna = 100 haleru

# Denmark



Denmark occupies the Jutland peninsula and over 400 islands in southern Scandinavia. Greenland and the Faeroe Islands are self-governing associated territories.



## GEOGRAPHY

Fertile farmland covers two-thirds of the terrain, which is among the flattest in the world. About 100 islands are inhabited.



## CLIMATE

Damp, temperate climate with mild summers and cold, wet winters. Rainfall is moderate.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Income distribution is the most even in the West: society is egalitarian with few tensions. Cultural clashes have arisen with immigrant minorities. Almost all women now work and Denmark is a world leader in childcare provision. Marriage is becoming less common, even for couples with children.



**INSIGHT:** Denmark is Europe's oldest kingdom – the monarchy dates back to the 10th century



## THE ECONOMY

Natural gas and oil reserves. Skilled workforce key to high-tech industrial success. Pork, bacon, dairy products are exported. Opted not to join the euro, though its currency is pegged.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Kingdom of Denmark

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 950

**CAPITAL:** Copenhagen

**POPULATION:** 5.47 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 16,639 sq. miles  
(43,094 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 334 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Danish

**RELIGIONS:** Evangelical Lutheran 89%, other 10%, Roman Catholic 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Danish 96%, other (including Scandinavian and Turkish) 3%, Faeroese and Inuit 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Danish krone = 100 øre



# Djibouti



A city-state with a desert hinterland, Djibouti lies in northeast Africa on the Red Sea. Once known as the French Territory of the Afars and Issas, independence came in 1977.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mainly low-lying desert and semidesert, with a volcanic mountain range in the north.



## CLIMATE

Almost no rain, though the monsoon is very humid. The 109°F (45°C) heat of summer is unbearable.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The main ethnic groups are the Issas in the south, and the nomadic Afars in the north. Tensions between them developed into a guerrilla war in 1991–1994. Smaller tribal groups make up the rest of the population, and the rural peoples are mostly nomadic. Wealth is concentrated in Djibouti city. France exerts considerable influence in Djibouti, supporting it financially and maintaining a naval base and a military garrison.

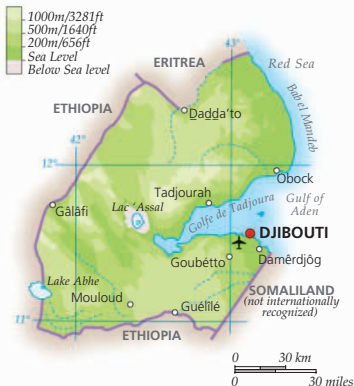


## THE ECONOMY

Djibouti's major assets are its ports in a key Red Sea location.



**INSIGHT:** *Chewing the leaves of the mildly narcotic qat shrub is an age-old social ritual in Djibouti*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Djibouti

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1977

**CAPITAL:** Djibouti

**POPULATION:** 864,200

**TOTAL AREA:** 8494 sq. miles  
(22,000 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 97 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Somali, Afar, French\*, Arabic\*

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim (mainly Sunni) 94%, Christian 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Issa 60%, Afar 35%, other 5%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Djibouti franc = 100 centimes

# Dominica



Dominica is renowned as the Caribbean island that resisted European colonization until the 18th century. It achieved independence from the UK in 1978.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mountainous and densely forested. Volcanic activity has given the land very fertile soils, hot springs, geysers, and black sand beaches.



## CLIMATE

Tropical, cooled by constant trade winds. Heavy annual rainfall. Tropical depressions and hurricanes are likely June–November.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The majority of Dominicans are descendants of African slaves brought over to work on banana plantations. The Carib Territory on the northeast of the island is home to the only surviving indigenous community in the Caribbean. Wealth disparities are not as marked as elsewhere in the region, but the alleviation of poverty has become a major plank of government policy.



## THE ECONOMY

Based on bananas, but has lost preferential access to EU market. Some diversification: flowers, coffee, fruit. Agriculture vulnerable to hurricanes. Eco-tourism. Some offshore banking.



**INSIGHT:** *Dominica is known as "Nature Island," due to its spectacular flora and fauna*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Commonwealth of Dominica

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1978

**CAPITAL:** Roseau

**POPULATION:** 70,400

**TOTAL AREA:** 291 sq. miles (754 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 243 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** French Creole, English\*

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 77%, Protestant 15%, other 8%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Black 87%, Mixed race 9%, Carib 3%, other 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** East Caribbean dollar  
= 100 cents



# Dominican Republic

The Dominican Republic occupies the eastern two-thirds of the island of Hispaniola in the Caribbean. Spanish-speaking, it seeks closer ties to the anglophone West Indies.



## GEOGRAPHY

Highlands and rainforested mountains – including the highest peak in the Caribbean, Pico Duarte – interspersed with fertile valleys. Extensive coastal plain in the east.



## CLIMATE

Hot and humid close to sea level, cooler at altitude. Heavy rainfall, especially in the northeast.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

White landowners – especially those descended from the original Spanish settlers – form the wealthy elite. Mixed-race majority controls commerce and forms the bulk of the professional middle classes. White and mixed-race women are entering the professions. Great disparities of wealth exist; the black and Haitian-immigrant populations occupy the bottom of the social ladder.



## THE ECONOMY

Mining (nickel and gold), sugar, and textiles. Tourism, remittances, and exports all rely heavily on US market. Hidden economy based on transshipment of narcotics to the US.



**INSIGHT:** *Santo Domingo is the oldest city in the Americas. It was founded in 1496 by the brother of Christopher Columbus*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Dominican Republic

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1865

**CAPITAL:** Santo Domingo

**POPULATION:** 10.1 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 18,679 sq. miles  
(48,380 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 540 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish\*, French Creole

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 92%, other and nonreligious 8%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mixed race 75%, White 15%, Black 10%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Dominican Republic peso  
= 100 centavos

# East Timor



East Timor occupies the once Portuguese-owned eastern half of the island of Timor. Invaded by Indonesia in 1975, it became independent in 2002 following a long struggle.



## GEOGRAPHY

A narrow coastal plain gives way to forested highlands. The mountain backbone rises to 9715 ft (2963 m).



## CLIMATE

Tropical. Heavy rain in wet season (December–March), then dry and hot, particularly in the north.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The population is almost entirely Roman Catholic. The Timorese are a mix of Malay and Papuan peoples, and many indigenous Papuan tribes survive. There is an urban Chinese minority, and ethnic Indonesian settlers became numerous after annexation in 1975. Preindependence violence in 1999 was politically rather than ethnically motivated. Women do not have access to the professions and levels of domestic violence are notably high. Living standards are low.



## THE ECONOMY

Widespread poverty. Violence in 1999 damaged infrastructure. Riots in 2006 undermined stability, further deterring foreign investment. Agreement with Australia on division of oil revenue from the Timor Sea.



**INSIGHT:** Once dependent on sandalwood, the economy is being transformed by oil under the Timor Sea



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Democratic Republic of Timor-Leste

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 2002

**CAPITAL:** Dili

**POPULATION:** 1.13 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 5756 sq. miles  
(14,874 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 201 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Tetum\*, Bahasa Indonesia, Portuguese\*

**RELIGIONS:** Catholic 95%, other 5%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Malay/Papuan groups c. 85%, Indonesian c. 13%, Chinese 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** US dollar = 100 cents



Once part of the Inca heartland, Ecuador lies on the western coast of South America. Its territory includes the fascinating Galápagos Islands, 610 miles (970 km) to the west.



## GEOGRAPHY

Broad coastal plain, inter-Andean central highlands, dense jungle in upper Amazon basin.



## CLIMATE

The climate is hot and moist on the coast, cool in the Andes, and hot equatorial in the Amazon basin.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people are of Amerindian-Spanish extraction (mestizo). Black communities exist on the coast. The strong and largely unified Amerindian movement leads the pressure for social reform; one in eight people live in extreme poverty. Recent left-wing policies have given greater rights to women, the poor, and Amerindians.



**INSIGHT:** *Darwin's study on the Galápagos Islands in 1856 played a major part in his theory of evolution*



## THE ECONOMY

Oil provides half of export earnings. World's biggest banana exporter. US dollar offers stability, but less control. Defaulted on debt in 2008, prioritizing social spending.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Ecuador

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1830

**CAPITAL:** Quito

**POPULATION:** 13.6 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 109,483 sq. miles  
(283,560 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 127 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish\*, Quechua, other Amerindian languages

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 93%; Protestant, Jewish, and other 7%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mestizo 55%, Amerindian 25%, White 10%, Black 10%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** US dollar = 100 cents

# Egypt



Occupying the northeast corner of Africa, Egypt is divided by the highly fertile Nile Valley. Its essentially pro-Western, military-backed regime is being challenged by Islamic fundamentalists.



## GEOGRAPHY

Fertile Nile Valley separates arid Libyan Desert from smaller semiarid eastern desert. Sinai peninsula has mountains in south.



## CLIMATE

Summers are very hot, but winters are cooler. Rainfall is negligible, except on the coast.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Despite a long tradition of ethnic and religious tolerance, the rise of Islam has sparked clashes between Muslims and Copts (Coptic Christianity is one of the Church's earliest branches). Women play a full part in education and the economy, though this is threatened by Islamism. Rapidly growing population is a problem. Poverty is rife around Cairo.



**INSIGHT:** In 450 BCE Herodotus visited the already-ancient pyramids



## THE ECONOMY

Oil and gas. Cotton. Tolls from the Suez Canal. Successful tourist industry, in spite of terrorist attacks. High birth-rate and rural poverty.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Arab Republic of Egypt

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1936

**CAPITAL:** Cairo

**POPULATION:** 83 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 386,660 sq. miles  
(1,001,450 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 216 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Arabic\*, French, English, Berber

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim (mainly Sunni) 94%, Coptic Christian and other 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Egyptian 99%, other (Nubian, Armenian, Greek, Berber) 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Egyptian pound = 100 piastres



# El Salvador



El Salvador is Central America's smallest and most densely populated country. Already struggling to recover from a civil war in the 1980s, it was badly struck by earthquakes in 2001.



## GEOGRAPHY

El Salvador is a narrow coastal belt backed by two mountain ranges. There is a central plateau. The country is located within a seismic zone, and there are more than 20 volcanic peaks.



## CLIMATE

Tropical coastal belt is very hot, with seasonal rains. Cooler, temperate climate in highlands.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Population is largely mestizo; ethnic tensions are few. The 1981–1991 civil war was fought between the US-backed right-wing government and left-wing FMLN guerrillas, over gross economic disparities, which still exist despite some reform. During the war, 75,000 people died, many of whom were unarmed civilians, and human rights abuses were widespread. The FMLN won the presidency in 2009.



## THE ECONOMY

Coffee, sugar. Garment industry. Remittances from overseas. Frequent natural disasters damage infrastructure and homes and deepen country's reliance on aid. Five-year anti-poverty program for north from 2007.



**INSIGHT:** *Independent since 1841, El Salvador is named after Jesus Christ, "the savior" of Christians*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of El Salvador

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1841

**CAPITAL:** San Salvador

**POPULATION:** 6.16 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 8124 sq. miles  
(21,040 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 770 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 80%,  
Evangelical 18%, other 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mestizo 94%, Amerindian 5%,  
White 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Salvadorean colón  
= 100 centavos; US dollar = 100 cents

# Equatorial Guinea



Comprising the mainland territory of Río Muni and five islands on the west coast of central Africa, Equatorial Guinea, despite its name, lies just north of the equator.



## GEOGRAPHY

The islands are mountainous and volcanic. The mainland is lower, with mangrove swamps along the coast.



## CLIMATE

The island of Bioko is extremely wet and humid. The mainland is only marginally drier and cooler.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Equatorial Guinea is the only Spanish-speaking country in Africa. Río Muni is sparsely populated and most people there are Fang, an ethnic group also found in Cameroon and northern Gabon. Bioko is populated by Bubi and a minority of Creoles known as Fernandinos. Tensions between the two territories have been reignited by the discovery of oil off Bioko. Wealth is concentrated in the ruling clan; oil revenue in the last decade has made little impact on most people.



## THE ECONOMY

Oil and gas now account for 97% of exports; the government has promised to reinvest the new funds in development. Timber, cocoa, coffee.



**INSIGHT:** In 2003, state radio declared President Obiang Nguema to be "like God in Heaven"



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Equatorial Guinea

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1968

**CAPITAL:** Malabo

**POPULATION:** 676,300

**TOTAL AREA:** 10,830 sq. miles  
(28,051 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 62 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish\*, Fang, Bubi, French\*

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 90%, other 10%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Fang 85%, other 11%, Bubi 4%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes



# Eritrea



Lying along the southwest shore of the Red Sea, Eritrea won a long war for independence from Ethiopia in 1993. The two neighbors fought a bitter border war in 1998–2000.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mostly consists of rugged mountains, bush, and the Danakil Desert, which falls below sea level.



## CLIMATE

Warm in the mountains; desert areas are hot. Droughts from July onward are common.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Tigrinya-speakers, mainly Orthodox Christians, are the most numerous of nine main ethnic groups. A strong sense of nationhood has been forged by war. Women played a vital role in combat. Over 80% of people are subsistence farmers. Multiparty elections, expected since 1997, have been persistently postponed.



**INSIGHT:** *Eritrea is the only country to secede successfully in postcolonial Africa*



## THE ECONOMY

Legacy of disruption and destruction from wars; resettlement of refugees. Susceptible to drought and famine: dependent on food aid. Most of the population live at subsistence level. Potential for extraction of gold, copper, and oil. Red Sea location: port at Massawa.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** State of Eritrea

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1993

**CAPITAL:** Asmara

**POPULATION:** 5.07 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 46,842 sq. miles  
(121,320 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 112 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Tigrinya\*, English\*, Tigre, Afar, Arabic\*, Bilen, Kunama, other

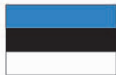
**RELIGIONS:** Christian 45%, Muslim 45%, other 10%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Tigray 50%, Tigre 31%, other 9%, Saho 5%, Afar 5%

**GOVERNMENT:** Transitional regime

**CURRENCY:** Nakfa = 100 cents

# Estonia



The smallest and most Western-oriented of the former Soviet-ruled Baltic states, Estonia is also the most developed, but its standard of living is well below the EU average.



## GEOGRAPHY

Estonia's terrain is flat, boggy, and partly forested, with over 1500 islands. Lake Peipus forms much of the eastern border with Russia.



## CLIMATE

Maritime, with some continental extremes. Harsh winters, with cool summers and damp springs.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Estonians are related ethnically and linguistically to the Finns. Friction between ethnic Estonians and the large Russian minority led to a reassertion of Estonian culture and language. Outright discrimination against the Russian language was only ended in 2000. Estonians are predominantly Lutheran. Families are small and divorce rates are high. Market reforms have increased prosperity; a few people have become very rich.



## THE ECONOMY

Timber and oil shale. Currency pegged to euro: hopes to join in 2011. Good productivity. Strong growth accompanied EU accession, but first EU country to enter recession in 2008.



**INSIGHT:** *Estonia pioneered online voting in 2007, and plans voting by cell phone in 2011*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Estonia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1991

**CAPITAL:** Tallinn

**POPULATION:** 1.34 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 17,462 sq. miles  
(45,226 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 77 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Estonian\*, Russian

**RELIGIONS:** Evangelical Lutheran 56%,  
Orthodox Christian 25%,  
other 19%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Estonian 68%, Russian 26%,  
other 4%, Ukrainian 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Kroon = 100 senti



# Ethiopia

The former empire of Ethiopia once dominated northeast Africa. A Marxist regime in 1974–1991, now a free-market democracy, it has suffered economic, civil, and natural crises.



## GEOGRAPHY

Great Rift Valley divides mountainous northwest region from desert lowlands in northeast and southeast. Ethiopian Plateau is drained mainly by the Blue Nile.



## CLIMATE

Moderate, with summer rains. Highlands are warm, with night frost and snowfalls on the mountains.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

76 Ethiopian nationalities speak 286 languages. Oromo (or Gallas) are the largest group. Ethnic representation is a major political issue. Orthodox Christianity has a very ancient history in Ethiopia. Former emperor Haile Selassie inspired Rastafarianism.

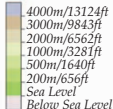


**INSIGHT:** *King Solomon and the Queen of Sheba are said to have founded the Kingdom of Abyssinia (Ethiopia) c. 1000 BCE*



## THE ECONOMY

Overwhelmingly dependent on agriculture; coffee is main export crop. War-damaged infrastructure and periodic serious droughts and famines undermine growth. There is a heavy reliance on food aid. Landlocked since secession of Eritrea.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1896

**CAPITAL:** Addis Ababa

**POPULATION:** 82.8 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 435,184 sq. miles  
(1,127,127 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 193 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Amharic\*, Tigrinya, other

**RELIGIONS:** Orthodox Christian 40%, Muslim 40%, traditional 15%, other 5%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Oromo 32%, Amhara 30%, other 26%, Tigray 6%, Somali 6%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Ethiopian birr = 100 cents

# Fiji



A volcanic archipelago in the South Pacific, with two large islands and 880 islets. Tensions between native Fijians and the Indian minority have sparked a succession of coups.



## GEOGRAPHY

Main islands are mountainous, fringed by coral reefs. Remainder are limestone and coral formations.



## CLIMATE

Tropical. High temperatures all year round. Cyclones are a hazard.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The British introduced workers from India in the late 19th century, and by 1946 their descendants outnumbered the indigenous Fijian population. Ethnic-Fijian nationalism is strong. Many Indo-Fijians left after the 1987 coup, restoring ethnic Fijians to a majority. In 2000, the first Indian-dominated government was ousted. The army led another coup in 2006. Women are lobbying for more rights.

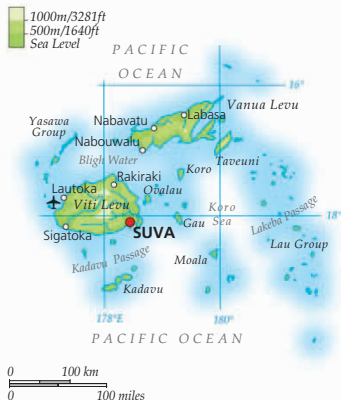


**INSIGHT:** Both Fijians and Indians practice fire-walking; Indians walk on hot embers, Fijians on heated stones



## THE ECONOMY

Tourism was main sector, though damaged by instability. Coups have also caused international isolation. All sectors struggling: sugar production, gold mining, textiles, timber, and commercial fishing.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of the Fiji Islands

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1970

**CAPITAL:** Suva

**POPULATION:** 849,200

**TOTAL AREA:** 7054 sq. miles  
(18,270 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 120 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Fijian, English\*, Hindi, Urdu, Tamil, Telugu

**RELIGIONS:** Hindu 38%, Methodist 37%, Catholic 9%, Muslim 8%, other 8%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Melanesian (Fijian) 51%, Indian 44%, other 5%

**GOVERNMENT:** Transitional regime

**CURRENCY:** Fiji dollar = 100 cents



## Finland



Finland's language and national identity have been influenced by both its Scandinavian and Russian neighbors. Once aligned with the USSR, Finland is now a member of the EU.

**GEOGRAPHY**

South and center are flat, with low hills and many lakes. Uplands and low mountains in the north. 60% of the land area is forested.

**CLIMATE**

Long, harsh winters with frequent snowfalls. Short, warmer summers. Rainfall is low, and decreases northward.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

One in four of the population lives in the Greater Helsinki region. Swedish-speakers live mainly in the Åland Islands in the southwest. The Sámi (Lapps) lead a seminomadic existence inside the Arctic Circle. Women make up 48% of the labor force, continuing a long tradition of equality between the sexes. Families tend to be close-knit, though marriage is becoming less common.

**THE ECONOMY**

Strong engineering and electronics sectors: home of Nokia. Wood, pulp, and paper production.



**INSIGHT:** *Finland has Europe's largest inland waterway system*

**FACTFILE**

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Finland

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1917

**CAPITAL:** Helsinki

**POPULATION:** 5.33 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 130,127 sq. miles  
(337,030 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 45 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Finnish\*, Swedish\*, Sámi

**RELIGIONS:** Evangelical Lutheran 89%, other 9%, Orthodox Christian 1%, Roman Catholic 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Finnish 93%, other (including Sámi) 7%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Euro = 100 cents

# France



Stretching across western Europe, from the English Channel (la Manche) to the Mediterranean Sea, France was Europe's first modern republic, and is still a leading industrial power.



## GEOGRAPHY

Broad plain covers northern half of the country. Tall mountain ranges in the east and southwest, with a mountainous plateau in the center.



## CLIMATE

Three main climates: temperate and damp northwest; continental east; and Mediterranean south.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Strong French national identity coexists with pronounced regional differences, including local languages. Immigration laws have been tightened since the 1970s, but ethnic minorities growing up in city suburbs feel increasingly alienated. New rules aim to bring more women into politics.



**INSIGHT:** France is the most popular tourist destination in the world, with over 80 million visitors a year



## THE ECONOMY

Chemicals, electronics, heavy engineering, cars, and aircraft typify a strong and diversified export sector. World leader in cosmetics, perfumes, and quality wines. Modernized agriculture.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** French Republic

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 987

**CAPITAL:** Paris

**POPULATION:** 62.3 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 211,208 sq. miles  
(547,030 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 294 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** French\*, Provençal, other

**RELIGIONS:** Catholic 88%, Muslim 8%, Protestant 2%, Jewish 1%, Buddhist 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** French 90%, North African 6%, German 2%, Breton 1%, other 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Mixed presidential-parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Euro = 100 cents



# Gabon

Gabon is a former French colony straddling the equator on Africa's west coast. Independent since 1960, it returned to multiparty politics in 1990, after 22 years of one-party rule.



## GEOGRAPHY

Low plateaus and mountains lie beyond the coastal strip. Two-thirds of the land is covered by rainforest.



## CLIMATE

Hot and tropical, with little distinction between seasons. Cold Benguela current cools the coast.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Some 40 different languages are spoken. The Fang, who live mainly in the north, are the largest ethnic group, but have yet to gain control of the government. Oil wealth has led to the growth of an affluent middle class, but one in three people still lives in poverty. Menial jobs are done by immigrant workers. Education follows the French system. With 85% of people living in towns, Gabon is one of Africa's most urbanized countries. The government is encouraging population growth.



## THE ECONOMY

Oil accounts for 80% of exports, but reserves are dwindling; not much post-oil planning. High debt problem. Tropical hardwoods and manganese.



**INSIGHT:** Libreville was founded as a settlement for freed French slaves in 1849



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Gabonese Republic

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1960

**CAPITAL:** Libreville

**POPULATION:** 1.47 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 103,346 sq. miles  
(267,667 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 15 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Fang, French\*, Punu, other

**RELIGIONS:** Christian (mainly Roman Catholic) 55%, traditional beliefs 40%, other 4%, Muslim 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Fang 26%, Shira-punu 24%, other 24%, foreign 15%, Nzabi-duma 11%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes

# Gambia



Gambia is a riverbank state on the west coast of Africa, almost entirely surrounded by Senegal. It was renowned for its stability until its government was overthrown in a coup in 1994.



## GEOGRAPHY

Located on the narrow strip of land bordering the Gambia River. Long, sandy beaches are backed by mangrove swamps along the river. Savanna and tropical forests higher up.



## CLIMATE

Subtropical, with wet, humid months July–October, and warm, dry season November–May.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Little tension between various ethnic groups. The largest group, the Mandinka, has traditionally held power. Islam is a strong social influence, though there is no official state religion. A small expatriate community from the UK lives on the coast. Seasonal migrants come from neighboring states to harvest groundnuts each year. Women are very active as traders.

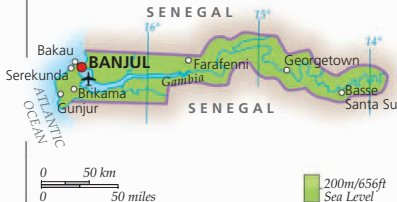


## THE ECONOMY

Around 70% of the labor force is involved in agriculture. Groundnuts are the principal crop. Fish stocks are declining. Eco-tourism is promoted, though most visitors come for the beaches. Banjul is one of west Africa's finest deepwater ports: significant re-export trade. Smuggling problems.



**INSIGHT:** *Overfishing in the waters off Gambia and Senegal, mainly by foreign vessels, is a growing problem*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of the Gambia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1965

**CAPITAL:** Banjul

**POPULATION:** 1.71 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 4363 sq. miles  
(11,300 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 442 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Mandinka, Fulani, Wolof, Jola, Soninke, English\*

**RELIGIONS:** Sunni Muslim 90%, Christian 9%, traditional beliefs 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mandinka 40%, Fulani 19%, Wolof 15%, Jola 11%, Serahuli 9%, other 6%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Dalasi = 100 butut



# Georgia

Located on the eastern shore of the Black Sea, Georgia has been torn by civil war and ethnic disputes since achieving independence from the Soviet Union in 1991.



## GEOGRAPHY

Kura Valley lies between Caucasus Mountains in the north and Lesser Caucasus range in south. Lowlands along the Black Sea coast.



## CLIMATE

Subtropical along the coast, changing to continental extremes at high altitudes. Rainfall is moderate.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Paternalistic society, with strong family, cultural, and literary traditions. Georgia was converted to Christianity in 326 CE. Armenians in the south are the poorest group. Civil conflicts in the early 1990s against Abkhaz and Osset separatists displaced 300,000 people. Abkhazia and South Ossetia now effectively operate as separate states, backed up by Russian forces since the 2008 war. Russia opposes Georgian hopes of joining the EU and NATO.



## THE ECONOMY

Transit revenues from pipelines taking oil to the West. Long-established and booming wine industry. Political instability. Fast pace of reforms in late 2000s, at cost of high unemployment.



**INSIGHT:** *Western Georgia was the land of the legendary Golden Fleece of Greek mythology*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Georgia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1991

**CAPITAL:** Tbilisi

**POPULATION:** 4.26 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 26,911 sq. miles  
(69,700 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 158 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Georgian\*, Russian, other

**RELIGIONS:** Georgian Orthodox 65%, Muslim 11%, Russian Orthodox 10%, Armenian Orthodox 8%, other 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Georgian 84%, Armenian 6%, Azeri 6%, Russian 2%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Lari = 100 tetri

# Germany



Europe's strongest industrial power and its most populous nation, Germany was divided after military defeat in 1945 into a free-market west and a communist east, but reunified in 1990.



## GEOGRAPHY

Central European coastal plains in the north, rising to rolling hills of central region and Alps in far south.



## CLIMATE

Damp, temperate in northern and central regions. Continental extremes in mountainous south.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Regionalism is strong. The north is mainly Protestant, while the south is staunchly Roman Catholic. Social and economic differences still exist between east and west. Turks are the largest single ethnic minority; many came as guest workers in the 1950s–1970s. Immigration rules now favor skilled workers. Feminism is strong.



**INSIGHT:** Germany's rivers and canals carry as much freight as its busy highways



## THE ECONOMY

Major exporter of electronics, heavy engineering, chemicals, and cars. Worst recession for 60 years in 2008–2009. Aging population.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Federal Republic of Germany

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1871

**CAPITAL:** Berlin

**POPULATION:** 82.2 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 137,846 sq. miles  
(357,021 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 609 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** German\*, Turkish

**RELIGIONS:** Protestant 34%, Roman Catholic 33%, other 30%, Muslim 3%

**ETHNIC MIX:** German 92%, other 3%, other European 3%, Turkish 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Euro = 100 cents



# Ghana



The heartland of the ancient Ashanti kingdom, Ghana in west Africa was once known as the Gold Coast. It has experienced intermittent periods of military rule since independence in 1957.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mostly low-lying. The west is covered by rainforest. One of the world's largest artificial lakes – Lake Volta – was created by damming the White Volta River.



## CLIMATE

Tropical. There are two wet seasons in the south, but the north is drier, and has just one.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Around 75 cultural-linguistic groups. The largest is the Akan, who include the Ashanti and Fanti peoples. Southern peoples are richer and more urban than those of the north. There are few tribal tensions. Family ties are strong. Women play a major role in market trading. The 2000 election saw Ghana's first peaceful handover of power. Poverty levels have been significantly reduced.



## THE ECONOMY

World's second-largest cocoa producer. Oil discovered in 2007: on stream in 2011. Hardwood trees such as maple and sapele. Gold mining.



**INSIGHT:** *Ghana was the first colony in west Africa to gain independence*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Ghana

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1957

**CAPITAL:** Accra

**POPULATION:** 23.8 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 92,100 sq. miles  
(238,540 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 268 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Twi, Fanti, Ewe, Ga, Adangbe, Gurma, Dagomba, English\*

**RELIGIONS:** Christian 69%, Muslim 16%, traditional beliefs 9%, other 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Akan 49%, Mole-Dagbani 17%, Ewe 13%, other 13%, Ga 8%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Cedi = 100 pesewas

## Greece



The Balkan state of Greece is bounded on three sides by the Mediterranean, Aegean, and Ionian seas. It has a strong seafaring tradition, with some of the world's richest shipowners.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Mountainous peninsula and over 2000 islands. Large plain along the mainland's Aegean coast.

**CLIMATE**

Mainly Mediterranean, with dry, hot summers. Alpine climate in northern mountain areas.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

Postwar industrial development altered the dominance of agriculture and seafaring. The rural exodus to industrial cities has been stemmed but a third of the population now lives in Athens. Age-old culture and Greek Orthodox Church balance social mobility. Civil marriage and divorce became legal only in 1982.



**INSIGHT:** *The modern Olympics, first held in Athens in 1896, evolved from Olympia's ancient Greek games*

**THE ECONOMY**

One of Europe's leading tourist destinations. World's largest shipping fleet. Fruit, vegetables, olives. Large black economy. Public debt and budget deficit remain high.

**FACTFILE**

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Hellenic Republic

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1829

**CAPITAL:** Athens

**POPULATION:** 11.2 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 50,942 sq. miles  
(131,940 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 221 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Greek\*, Turkish, Macedonian, Albanian

**RELIGIONS:** Orthodox Christian 98%, Muslim 1%, other 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Greek 98%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Euro = 100 cents



# Grenada

The southernmost of the Windward Islands, Grenada made world headlines in 1983 when the US and Caribbean allies mounted an invasion to sever links with Castro's Cuba.



## GEOGRAPHY

Volcanic in origin, with densely forested central mountains. Its territory also includes the islands of Carriacou and Petite Martinique.



## CLIMATE

Tropical, tempered by trade winds. Hurricanes are a hazard in the July–November wet season.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Grenadians are mainly of African origin; their traditions remain strong, especially on Carriacou. Inter-ethnic marriage has reduced tensions between the groups. Extended families, often headed by women, are the norm. Wealth disparities are not marked, but levels of poverty are growing.

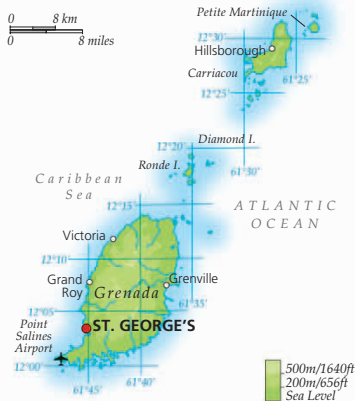


**INSIGHT:** Known as “the spice island of the Caribbean,” it is the world’s second-largest nutmeg producer



## THE ECONOMY

Severe damage from Hurricane Ivan in 2004 to crops and 90% of buildings; reconstruction will take years. Nutmeg, cocoa, bananas, and mace. Smuggling is a serious problem.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Grenada

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1974

**CAPITAL:** St. George's

**POPULATION:** 103,900

**TOTAL AREA:** 131 sq. miles  
(340 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 793 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** English\*, English Creole

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 68%,  
Anglican 17%, other 15%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Black African 82%,  
Mixed race 13%, East Indian 3%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** East Caribbean dollar =  
100 cents

# Guatemala



The largest and most populous nation on the Central American isthmus, Guatemala returned to civilian rule in 1986 after 32 years of violent and repressive military rule.



## GEOGRAPHY

Narrow Pacific coastal plain. Central highlands with volcanoes. Short coast on the Caribbean Sea. Tropical rainforests in the north.



## CLIMATE

Tropical: hot and humid in coastal regions and north. More temperate in central highlands.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Amerindians, concentrated in the highlands, form a majority. Power, wealth, and land are controlled by *ladinos* (Westernized Amerindians and *mestizos*). Catholicism is predominant, mixed with Amerindian beliefs. A third of the population lives on less than \$2 a day. Literacy levels are low.



**INSIGHT:** *Guatemala, which means "land of trees," was the center of the ancient Mayan civilization*



## THE ECONOMY

Coffee, sugar, and bananas are top exports. Tourism. Damage from natural disasters. Marked wealth inequalities inhibit domestic market.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Guatemala

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1838

**CAPITAL:** Guatemala City

**POPULATION:** 14 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 42,042 sq. miles  
(108,890 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 335 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Quiché, Mam, Cakchiquel, Kekchí, Spanish\*

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 65%, Protestant 33%, other 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Amerindian 60%, Mestizo 30%, other 10%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Quetzal = 100 centavos



# Guinea

Located on the west coast of Africa, Guinea became the first French colony in Africa to gain independence, in 1958.

The country was under military rule from 1984 to 1995.



## GEOGRAPHY

Coastal plains and mangrove swamps in west rise to forested or savanna highlands in the south. Semidesert in the north.



## CLIMATE

Tropical, with a wet season April–October. Conakry is especially rainy. Hot, dry *harmattan* wind blows from Sahara during dry season.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Peul and Malinké make up most of the population, but rivalries between them have allowed coastal peoples such as the Soussou to dominate politics. Daily life revolves around the extended family. Women acquired influence under Marxist party rule between 1958 and 1984, but the Muslim revival since then has reversed the trend. Private enterprise has created a business class.



## THE ECONOMY

Substantial gold, diamond, and especially bauxite reserves. Cash crops: bananas, coffee, pineapples, palm oil. Poor infrastructure. Instability.



**INSIGHT:** The colors of Guinea's flag represent the three words of the country's motto: work (red), justice (yellow), and solidarity (green)



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Guinea

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1958

**CAPITAL:** Conakry

**POPULATION:** 10.1 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 94,925 sq. miles  
(245,857 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 106 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Pulaar, Malinké, Soussou, French\*

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim 65%, traditional beliefs 33%, Christian 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Peul 39%, Malinké 23%, other 21%, Soussou 11%, Kissi 6%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Guinea franc = 100 centimes

# Guinea-Bissau



Known as Portuguese Guinea while a colony, Guinea-Bissau lies on Africa's west coast. Since 1994, its nascent democracy has been plagued by coups and rebellions.



## GEOGRAPHY

Low-lying, apart from savanna highlands in northeast. Rainforests and swamps are found along coastal areas.



## CLIMATE

Tropical, with wet season May–November and dry season December–April. Hot, dry *harmattan* desert wind blows during dry season.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The largest ethnic group is the Balante, who live in the south. Though only around 1% of the population, the mixed Portuguese–African *mestiços* dominate the top ranks of government and bureaucracy. Most people live and work on small family farms, grouped in self-contained villages. The bulk of the urban population live in Bissau, where they face economic hardship. Narcotics traffickers are taking advantage of the ongoing instability.



## THE ECONOMY

Mostly subsistence farming. Lack of sufficiency in rice staple. Main cash crop is cashew nuts. Major cocaine transit route from South America to Europe. Offshore oil as yet untapped. Fisheries and timber potential.



**INSIGHT:** In 1974, Guinea-Bissau became the first Portuguese colony to gain independence



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Rep. of Guinea-Bissau

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1974

**CAPITAL:** Bissau

**POPULATION:** 1.61 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 13,946 sq. miles  
(36,120 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 148 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Portuguese Creole, Balante, Fulani, Malinke, Portuguese\*

**RELIGIONS:** Indigenous beliefs 52%, Muslim 40%, Christian 8%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Balante 30%, other 24%, Fulani 20%, Mandyako 14%, Mandinka 12%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** CFA franc = 100 centimes



# Guyana



On the northeast coast of South America, Guyana is the continent's only English-speaking country. Independent since 1966, it has close ties with the anglophone Caribbean.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mainly artificial coast, reclaimed by dikes and dams from swamps and tidal marshes. Forests cover 85% of the interior, rising to savanna uplands and mountains.



## CLIMATE

Tropical. Coast cooled by sea breezes. Lowlands are hot, wet, and humid. Highlands are a little cooler.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Guyana is a complex multiracial society. Tension exists between the Afro-Guyanese, descended from slaves, and the Indo-Guyanese, descendants of laborers brought over after slavery was abolished. Politics is highly polarized around this split and has often spilled over into violence on the streets. Amerindian subsistence farmers are the poorest people in society and have little representation.



## THE ECONOMY

Diverse exports: gold, sugar, fish, bauxite, rice, timber, diamonds. Debt relief granted. Narcotics transit zone.



**INSIGHT:** *Guyana means "land of many waters," reflecting its dense network of rivers*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Cooperative Republic of Guyana

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1966

**CAPITAL:** Georgetown

**POPULATION:** 762,500

**TOTAL AREA:** 83,000 sq. miles  
(214,970 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 10 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Creole, Hindi, English\*

**RELIGIONS:** Christian 57%, Hindu 33%, Muslim 9%, other 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** East Indian 43%, Black African 30%, other 18%, Amerindian 9%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Guyanese dollar = 100 cents

## Haiti



Formerly a French colony, Haiti shares the Caribbean island of Hispaniola with the Dominican Republic. At independence in 1804, it became the world's first black republic.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Predominantly mountainous, with forests and fertile plains.

**CLIMATE**

Tropical, with rain throughout the year. Humid in coastal areas, much cooler in the mountains.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

Most Haitians are of African descent. A few have European roots, primarily French. The rigid class structure maintains vast disparities of wealth. The majority of the population live in extreme poverty; Haiti is one of the poorest countries in the Americas. A combination of political oppression and a collapsing economy led thousands to seek asylum in the US or the Dominican Republic. Though most are Christians, many Haitians practice Voodoo, which was recognized as an official religion in 2003.

**THE ECONOMY**

In crisis due to instability, hurricane damage, and corruption. Profiteering from narcotics trade to US. Food shortages. 70% unemployment.



**INSIGHT:** A slave rebellion headed by Toussaint Louverture in 1791 led to Haiti's independence

**FACTFILE**

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Haiti

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1804

**CAPITAL:** Port-au-Prince

**POPULATION:** 10 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 10,714 sq. miles  
(27,750 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 943 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** French Creole\*, French

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 80%, Protestant 16%, other 3%, nonreligious 1%; Voodoo is widely practiced

**ETHNIC MIX:** Black African 95%, Mixed race and European 5%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Gourde = 100 centimes



# Honduras

Straddling the Central American isthmus, Honduras returned to democratic rule in 1984, after a period of military government. Hurricane Mitch devastated the country in 1998.



## GEOGRAPHY

Narrow plains along both coasts, with a mountainous interior, cut by river valleys. Tropical forests, swamps, and lagoons in the east.



## CLIMATE

Tropical coastal lowlands are hot and humid, with May–October rains. Interior is cooler and drier.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The majority of the population is *mestizo* (mixed race). An English-speaking *garifuna* (black) community and Miskito Amerindians struggle to preserve their rights to land along the remote Caribbean coast. Women's status remains low. Hurricane Mitch impoverished 85% of the population. Wealth inequalities are large and poverty is at the root of social tension. The army ousted the president in 2009. Violent crime is a major issue.



## THE ECONOMY

Garments, coffee, bananas, and shellfish are exported. Remittances account for a fifth of GDP. Debt relief from 2005. Mineral potential. High underemployment and corruption.



**INSIGHT:** *The Honduran currency is named after a Lenca Indian chief who was the main leader of resistance to the Spanish conquest in the 16th century*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Honduras

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1838

**CAPITAL:** Tegucigalpa

**POPULATION:** 7.47 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 43,278 sq. miles  
(112,090 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 173 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish\*, Garifuna, English Creole

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 97%, Protestant 3%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Mestizo 90%, Black African 5%, Amerindian 4%, White 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Transitional regime

**CURRENCY:** Lempira = 100 centavos

# Hungary



Landlocked in central Europe, Hungary was one of the twin centers of the once-great Habsburg Empire. It lost two-thirds of its historical territory for supporting Germany in World War I.



## GEOGRAPHY

Landlocked. Fertile plains in east and northwest; west and north are hilly. The Danube River cuts through the country and the capital.



## CLIMATE

Continental, with wet springs, late but very hot summers, and cold, cloudy winters. The transition between seasons tends to be sudden.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Hungary's population shrank in the 1990s. Mostly ethnic Hungarian (Magyar), there are small minorities of Germans, Jews, and neighboring peoples. Roma face particular discrimination. The government is greatly concerned about the fate of ethnic Hungarians in Romania, Serbia, and Slovakia. Hungary joined the EU in 2004. Working hours are longer than in western Europe.



## THE ECONOMY

Strong industrial base. Hard-hit in 2007–2008 "global downturn." Currency plummeted, \$25 billion from IMF to avoid meltdown. Tough spending cuts needed to keep on path to join euro.



**INSIGHT:** *The Hungarian language is Asian in origin and is most closely related to Finnish*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Hungary

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1918

**CAPITAL:** Budapest

**POPULATION:** 9.99 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 35,919 sq. miles  
(93,030 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 280 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Hungarian\*

**RELIGIONS:** Catholic 52%, Calvinist 16%, other 15%, nonreligious 14%, Lutheran 3%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Magyar 94%, other 5%, Roma 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Forint = 100 fillér



# Iceland



Europe's westernmost country, Iceland's strategic ocean location straddles the Mid-Atlantic Ridge. Its spectacular landscape is largely uninhabited, aside from coastal towns.



## GEOGRAPHY

Grassy coastal lowlands, with fjords in the north. Central plateau of cold lava desert, geothermal springs, and glaciers. Around 200 volcanoes, with numerous geysers and solfataras.



## CLIMATE

Its location in the middle of the Gulf Stream moderates the climate. Mild winters and brief, cool summers.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Icelanders share a strong national identity, with few foreign residents. Their language has changed little in 700 years, in part due to the country's isolation. There is high social mobility, free health care, and low-cost heating (geothermal and hydropower). Iceland's recent banking collapse and near financial ruin has swung the long-running debate over EU membership in favor of joining.



## THE ECONOMY

Once reliant on fish. Aluminum smelting. Tourism. Banks overexposed in 2007–2008 "global downturn." Nation bankrupt, króna depreciated 90%.



**INSIGHT:** The word *geyser* is taken from *Geysir* (the "gusher") in southwest Iceland



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Iceland

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1944

**CAPITAL:** Reykjavík

**POPULATION:** 322,700

**TOTAL AREA:** 39,768 sq. miles  
(103,000 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 8 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Icelandic\*

**RELIGIONS:** Evangelical Lutheran 93%,  
nonreligious 6%,  
other (mostly Christian) 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Icelandic 94%, other 5%,  
Danish 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Icelandic króna = 100 aurar

# India



India is the world's second most populous country and largest democracy. Despite some success in reducing the birth rate, its population will probably overtake China's by 2035.



## GEOGRAPHY

Separated from northern Asia by the Himalaya mountain range, India forms a subcontinent. As well as the Himalayas, there are two other main geographical regions, the Indo-Gangetic plain, which lies between the foothills of the Himalayas and the Vindhya Mountains, and the central-southern Deccan plateau. The Ghats are smaller mountain ranges located on the east and west coasts.



## CLIMATE

Varies greatly according to latitude, altitude, and season. Most of India has three seasons: hot, wet, and cool. Summer temperatures in the north can reach 104°F (40°C). Monsoon rains normally break in June, petering out in September to October. In the cool season, the weather is mainly dry. The climate in the warmer south is less variable than in the north.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

India's planners, overseeing an economic revolution, see its growing population rather than environmental constraints as the main brake on development. Nationwide awareness campaigns promote birth control but cultural and religious pressures encourage large families. Rural deprivation spurs urban migration, to live in sprawling slums. Almost 70% of people survive on less than \$2 a day. The majority of Indians are Hindu. Various attempts to reform the Hindu caste system, which determines social standing and even marriage, have met with violent opposition. Severe tensions exist between Hindus and the Muslim minority, especially in Kashmir and Gujarat. Smaller ethnic groups exist in the northeast, and many struggle for greater autonomy. Over two million people are living with HIV/AIDS.

## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of India

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1947

**CAPITAL:** New Delhi

**POPULATION:** 1.2 billion

**TOTAL AREA:** 1,269,338 sq. miles  
(3,287,590 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 1044 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Hindi\*, English\*, Urdu, Bengali, Marathi, Telugu, Tamil, other

**RELIGIONS:** Hindu 81%, Muslim 13%, Christian 2%, Sikh 2%, other 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Indo-Aryan 72%, Dravidian 25%, Mongoloid and other 3%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

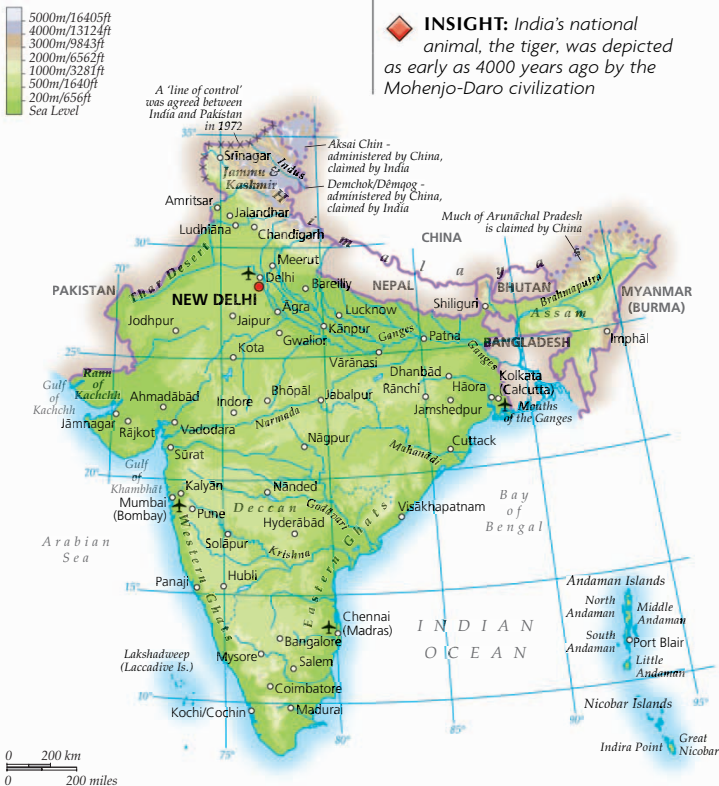
**CURRENCY:** Indian rupee = 100 paise

## THE ECONOMY

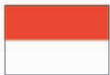
One of Asia's fastest-growing economies. Protectionism has given way to free-market economics. Tea, gems,

textiles exported. High-tech industries, outsourcing center. Success of "Bollywood" films. Cheap labor. Huge market, held back by poverty.

 **INSIGHT:** India's national animal, the tiger, was depicted as early as 4000 years ago by the Mohenjo-Daro civilization



# Indonesia



Formerly called the Dutch East Indies, Indonesia is the world's largest archipelago, with 18,108 islands scattered across 3000 miles (5000 km). It is the world's fourth most populous nation.



## GEOGRAPHY

Indonesia is highly mountainous, with numerous tropical swamps. The land is covered with dense rainforest, especially on New Guinea, where it remains largely unexplored. There are more than 200 volcanoes, many of which are still active. Earthquakes, eruptions, and tsunamis are hazards. The islands of Java, Bali, Lombok, Sumatra, and Borneo were once joined together by dry land, which has since been submerged by rising sea levels. Coastal lowland development distinguishes some of the large islands.



## CLIMATE

The climate is predominantly tropical monsoon. Variations relate mainly to differences in latitude and altitude; hilly areas are cooler overall. Rain falls throughout the year, often in thunderstorms, but there is a relatively dry season from June to September.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The basic Melanesian–Malay ethnic division disguises a diverse society. Bahasa Indonesia, the national language, coexists with at least 250 other spoken languages or dialects. Attempts by the Javanese



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Indonesia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1949

**CAPITAL:** Jakarta

**POPULATION:** 230 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 741,096 sq. miles  
(1,919,440 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 332 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Javanese, Sundanese, Madurese, Bahasa Indonesia\*, Dutch

**RELIGIONS:** Sunni Muslim 87%, Christian 9%, Hindu 2%, other 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Javanese 42%, other 31%, Sundanese 15%, coastal Malays 12%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

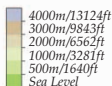
**CURRENCY:** Rupiah = 100 sen

political elite to suppress local cultures have been vigorously opposed, especially by the Aceh of northern Sumatra, and the Papuans. Religious and interethnic hostility is a problem, with clashes between Christians and Muslims in many areas, and discrimination against ethnic Chinese leading to mob attacks on their businesses. Gender equality is enshrined in law; women are active in public life.

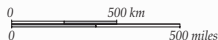


## THE ECONOMY

Varied resources, especially natural gas. Cheap and plentiful labor pool. Sizable state-owned sector, and state control of prices of basic goods. Large foreign debt rescheduled. Bureaucracy and corruption damage business confidence. Regional conflicts and terrorist attacks deter tourists and investors. Piracy is rife. The 2004 tsunami, which killed over 130,000 people, devastated northern Sumatra.



**INSIGHT:** Indonesia has a very youthful population: almost 30% of its people are under 15 years of age



# Iran



Since the 1979 Islamic fundamentalist revolution led by Ayatollah Khomeini, the Middle Eastern country of Iran has been the world's largest theocracy.



## GEOGRAPHY

High desert plateau with large salt pans in the east. West and north are mountainous. Coastal land bordering Caspian Sea is rainy and forested.



## CLIMATE

Desert climate. Hot summers, and bitterly cold winters. Area around the Caspian Sea is more temperate.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Many ethnic groups, including Persians, Azaris (ethnically related to Azeris), and Kurds. Militant Shi'a Islamism has dominated since the 1979 revolution. The mullahs' belief that adherence to religious values is more important than economic welfare has resulted in declining living standards. Female emancipation has been reversed. Student-backed demonstrations favoring greater liberalism have been suppressed.



## THE ECONOMY

A leading oil producer: 80% of exports. Government restricts contact with the West, blocking acquisition of vital technology. High unemployment and inflation. Sizable black market.



**INSIGHT:** *More than a hundred offenses carry the death penalty*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Islamic Republic of Iran

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1502

**CAPITAL:** Tehran

**POPULATION:** 74.2 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 636,293 sq. miles  
(1,648,000 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 117 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Farsi\*, Azeri, Luri, Gilaki, Mazanderani, Kurdish, Turkmen, Arabic

**RELIGIONS:** Shi'a Muslim 93%,  
Sunni Muslim 6%, other 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Persian 50%, Azari 24%,  
other 10%, Kurd 8%, Lur and Bakhtiari 8%

**GOVERNMENT:** Islamic theocracy

**CURRENCY:** Iranian rial = 100 dinars



# Iraq



Oil-rich Iraq is situated in the central Middle East. The last 50 years have been dominated by dictatorship, war, and civil strife. A US-led Coalition ousted Saddam Hussein in April 2003.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mainly desert. The Tigris and Euphrates rivers water fertile regions and create the southern marshland. Mountains along northeast border.



## CLIMATE

Southern deserts have hot, dry summers and mild winters. North has dry summers, but winters can be harsh in the mountains. Rainfall is low.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Carved out of remnants of the Ottoman Empire, Iraq is home to Arab Muslims (mainly Shi'a, some Sunni), northern Kurds (who were persecuted under Saddam's regime), and smaller minorities. Since Saddam's removal, sectarian violence has overshadowed the new democratic state. Now that security is improving, Coalition forces are pulling out. After years of war and sanctions, poverty is widespread.



## THE ECONOMY

Economy and infrastructure have been destroyed. Given stability and aid for reconstruction, hopes of recovery rest on massive oil reserves.



**INSIGHT:** As Mesopotamia, Iraq was the site where the Sumerians established the world's first civilization



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Iraq

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1932

**CAPITAL:** Baghdad

**POPULATION:** 30.7 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 168,753 sq. miles  
(437,072 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 182 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Arabic\*, Kurdish,

Turkic languages, Armenian, Assyrian

**RELIGIONS:** Shi'a Muslim 60%, Sunni Muslim 35%, other 5%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Arab 80%, Kurdish 15%, Turkmen 3%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** New Iraqi dinar = 1000 fils

# Ireland



In the Atlantic Ocean off the west coast of Britain, the Irish Republic governs about 85% of the island of Ireland, with the remainder (Northern Ireland) being part of the UK.



## GEOGRAPHY

Low mountain ranges along an irregular coastline surround an inland plain punctuated by lakes, undulating hills, and peat bogs.



## CLIMATE

The Gulf Stream accounts for the mild and wet climate. Snow is rare, except in the mountains.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Though homogeneous in ethnicity and Roman Catholic by religion, society has undergone a major generational change, liberalizing birth control, divorce, abortion, and general attitudes. Traditionally an emigrant nation, there is now net immigration. The Good Friday peace agreement over Northern Ireland was reached in 1998.



**INSIGHT:** About 40% of Irish people can speak Irish Gaelic



## THE ECONOMY

Strong growth until 2008, when housing bubble burst and banks faltered. Struggling to cut budget deficit. Skilled workforce. Efficient agriculture, food-processing, and electronics industries.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Ireland

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1922

**CAPITAL:** Dublin

**POPULATION:** 4.52 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 27,135 sq. miles  
(70,280 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 170 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** English\*, Irish Gaelic\*

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 88%,  
other and nonreligious 9%,  
Anglican 3%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Irish 99%, other 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary  
system

**CURRENCY:** Euro = 100 cents



# Israel



Created as a new state in 1948, Israel lies on the eastern Mediterranean. The current phase of the Palestinian intifada (armed struggle) against Israeli occupation began in 2000.



## GEOGRAPHY

Coastal plain. Desert in the south. In the east lie the Great Rift Valley and the Dead Sea – the lowest point on the Earth's land surface.



## CLIMATE

Summers are hot and dry. Wet season, March–November, is mild.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Large numbers of Jews settled in Palestine before Israel was founded in 1948. After World War II, there was a massive increase in immigration. Sephardi Jews from the Middle East and Mediterranean are now in the majority, but Ashkenazi Jews from central Europe still dominate business and politics. Palestinians in Gaza and Jericho gained limited autonomy in 1994 but their desire, backed by most of the world, for a separate state has led to years of fierce violence.



## THE ECONOMY

High-tech industries, modern infrastructure and educated workforce, but hampered by conflict and boycotts.



**INSIGHT:** All Jews worldwide have the right to Israeli citizenship



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** State of Israel

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1948

**CAPITAL:** Jerusalem (unrecognized by UN)

**POPULATION:** 7.17 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 8019 sq. miles  
(20,770 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 913 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Hebrew\*, Arabic\*, Yiddish, German, Russian, Polish, other

**RELIGIONS:** Jewish 76%, Muslim (mainly Sunni) 16%, other 6%, Christian 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Jewish 76%, other (mostly Arab) 24%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Shekel = 100 agorot



The Italian peninsula was home to the Roman Empire, one of the greatest ancient civilizations. The south has two famous volcanoes, Vesuvius and Etna.



## GEOGRAPHY

The Apennines form the backbone of a rugged peninsula, extending from the Alps into the Mediterranean Sea. Alluvial plain in the north.



## CLIMATE

Mediterranean in the south. Seasonal extremes in the mountains and on the northern alluvial plain.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnically homogeneous, but with a gulf between the prosperous, industrial north and the poorer, agricultural south. Strong regional identities persist, especially on Sicily and Sardinia. Family ties remain strong, though the influence of the Roman Catholic Church has lessened.



**INSIGHT:** *Italy was a collection of dukedoms, monarchies, and city-states before unification in the 1860s*



## THE ECONOMY

World leader in industrial and product design, fashion, textiles. Strong tourism and agriculture sectors. Large public sector debt.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Italian Republic

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1861

**CAPITAL:** Rome

**POPULATION:** 59.9 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 116,305 sq. miles  
(301,230 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 527 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Italian\*, German, French, Rhaeto-Romanic, Sardinian

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 85%, other and nonreligious 13%, Muslim 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Italian 94%, other 4%, Sardinian 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Euro = 100 cents



# Jamaica

First colonized by the Spanish and then by the English, the Caribbean island of Jamaica achieved independence in 1962. It remains an influential force in Caribbean politics.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mainly mountainous, with lush tropical vegetation. Inaccessible limestone area in the northwest. Low, irregular coastal plains are broken by hills and plateaus.



## CLIMATE

Tropical. Hot and humid at sea level, with temperate mountain areas. Hurricanes are likely June–November.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Social tensions result from vast disparities in wealth, rather than race. Economic and political life is dominated by a few wealthy, long-established families. Many women hold senior positions in public life. Armed crime, much of it narcotics-related, is a problem. Large areas of Kingston, which have their own patois, are ruled by violent gangs. Jamaican music styles are influential worldwide.

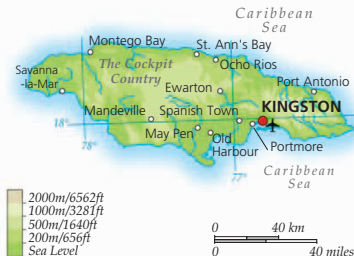


## THE ECONOMY

Major bauxite producer, though sector suffering from low world prices. Tourism and light industry. Sugar, bananas, coffee, and rum are exported. Debt burden dominates budget. High underemployment.



**INSIGHT:** *Jamaica's Rastafarians revere the late emperor of Ethiopia, Haile Selassie, as their spiritual leader, and see Africa as their spiritual home*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Jamaica

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1962

**CAPITAL:** Kingston

**POPULATION:** 2.72 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 4243 sq. miles  
(10,990 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 650 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** English Creole, English\*

**RELIGIONS:** Protestant 55%,  
other and nonreligious 45%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Black African 92%,  
Mulatto 6%, European and Chinese 1%,  
East Indian 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Jamaican dollar = 100 cents

# Japan



Japan is located off the east Asian coast and comprises four principal islands and over 3000 smaller ones. A powerful economy, it has an emperor as ceremonial head of state.



## GEOGRAPHY

The terrain is predominantly mountainous, with fertile coastal plains; over two-thirds is woodland. There is no single continuous mountain range; the mountains divide into many small land blocks separated by lowlands and dissected by numerous river valleys. The islands lie on the Pacific "Ring of Fire," and earthquakes and volcanic eruptions are frequent. The Pacific coast is vulnerable to *tsunamis*. There are numerous hot springs.



## CLIMATE

Generally temperate-oceanic. Spring is warm and sunny, while summer is hot and humid, with high rainfall. In western Hokkaido and northwest Honshu, winters are very cold, with heavy snowfall. Freak storms and damaging floods in recent years have raised concern over global climate changes.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

One of the most racially homogeneous societies in the world. A sense of order and social structure was founded on a strongly ingrained respect for elders and social superiors. In business, this underpinned the now much-diluted "lifetime employer" concept, where company allegiance determined social life as well as career. There is little tradition of generational rebellion, but the youth market is powerful and current fashions focus on teenagers. The education system is highly pressurized. Nongraduates have difficulty reaching management-level jobs, so competition for university places is intense. Long-term jobs for women are now the norm. One of the world's best healthcare systems and increased longevity have led to an aging population, with one in five people already over 65. The cost of living is high, especially in Tokyo.

## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Japan

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1590

**CAPITAL:** Tokyo

**POPULATION:** 127 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 145,882 sq. miles  
(377,835 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 875 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Japanese\*, Korean, Chinese

**RELIGIONS:** Shinto and Buddhist 76%, Buddhist 16%, other (including Christian) 8%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Japanese 99%, other (mainly Korean) 1%

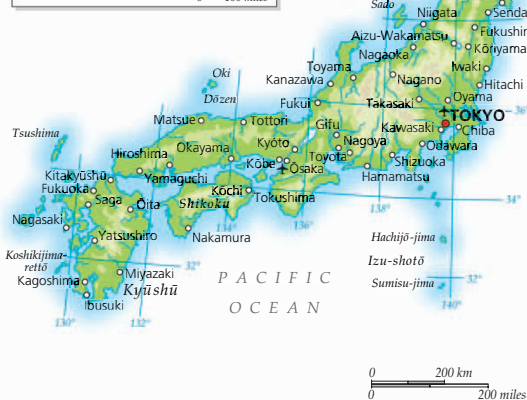
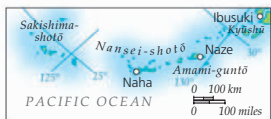
**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Yen = 100 sen

## THE ECONOMY

World's second-largest economy. Established market leader in high-tech electronic goods and cars. Talent for developing ideas from abroad. Global spread of business – especially to EU, US. Once-revolutionary management and production methods. Long-term research and development. Largest coal importer. Trade surplus causes international tension. Protectionism in domestic economy. Much-needed reform of financial sector has been obstructed by traditional economic power brokers. Significant aid donor.

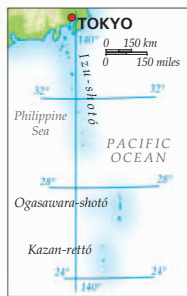
 **INSIGHT:** *The Japanese are among the world's most avid newspaper readers, with daily sales exceeding 70 million copies*



PACIFIC OCEAN

Honshū

2000m/6562ft  
1000m/3281ft  
500m/1640ft  
Sea Level



# Jordan



The Kingdom of Jordan lies east of Israel, and borders the Palestinian West Bank. Its relations with its Arab neighbors are troubled by its relatively close ties to the US.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mostly desert plateaus, with occasional salt pans. Lowest parts lie along the eastern shores of the Dead Sea and the Jordan River.



## CLIMATE

Hot, dry summers. Cool, wet winters. Areas below sea level very hot in summer, and warm in winter.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Jordan is predominantly Muslim with a strong national identity, but its people have Bedouin roots. There is a Christian minority, while Palestinians who have emigrated from Israeli-occupied territory make up a third of the population. Jordan ceded its claim to the West Bank to the aspiring Palestinian state in 1988. The monarchy's power base lies among the rural tribes, which also provide the backbone of the military.

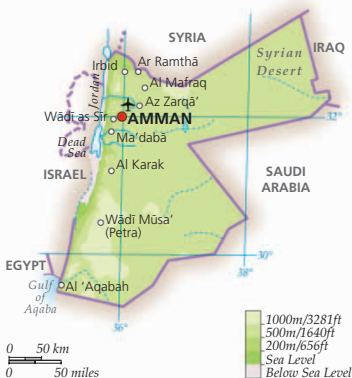


## THE ECONOMY

Lack of water. Exports garments, potash, fertilizers, and phosphates. Tourism hit by regional instability.



**INSIGHT:** *The Nabataean ruins of the ancient city of Petra attract thousands of tourists every year*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1946

**CAPITAL:** Amman

**POPULATION:** 6.32 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 35,637 sq. miles  
(92,300 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 184 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Arabic

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim (mainly Sunni) 92%, other (mostly Christian) 8%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Arab 98%, Circassian 1%, Armenian 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Monarchy

**CURRENCY:** Jordanian dinar = 1000 fils



# Kazakhstan

Kazakhstan was the last of the former Soviet republics to declare independence. Foreign investment in the oil and natural gas sector is strengthening its regional power.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mainly steppe. Volga Delta and Caspian Sea in the west. Central plateau. Inhospitable Altai Mountains in the east. Semidesert in the south.



## CLIMATE

Dry continental. Temperature variations between desert south and northern steppes are large. Winters are mildest near the Caspian Sea.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Kazakhstan's ethnic diversity arose mainly from forced settlements there during Soviet times. Since independence, the proportion of ethnic Russians has dropped. Many emigrated, while ethnic Kazakhs arrived from neighboring states. Very few Kazakhs maintain a traditional nomadic lifestyle, but Islam and loyalty to clans remain strong. There are significant disparities of wealth.



## THE ECONOMY

Vast mineral resources: natural gas, oil, bismuth, uranium, and cadmium. Oil pipelines to China and Black Sea. Many Western investors. Wheat exported. Sale of farmland only legal since 2003.



**INSIGHT:** *The Soviet-built Baykonur space center is still an important launch site for international missions*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Kazakhstan

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1991

**CAPITAL:** Astana

**POPULATION:** 15.6 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 1,049,150 sq. miles  
(2,717,300 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 15 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Kazakh\*, Russian, Ukrainian, Tatar, Uzbek, Uighur, other

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim (mainly Sunni) 47%, Orthodox Christian 44%, other 9%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Kazakh 57%, Russian 27%, other 10%, Ukrainian 3%, Uzbek 3%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Tenge = 100 tiyn

# Kenya



Kenya straddles the equator on Africa's east coast. After nearly 40 years in power, the KANU party was soundly defeated in elections in 2002. Corruption is a serious issue.



## GEOGRAPHY

A central plateau is divided by the Great Rift Valley. North of the equator is mainly semidesert. To the east lies a fertile coastal belt.



## CLIMATE

The coast and the Great Rift Valley are hot and humid. The plateau interior is temperate. The northeastern desert is hot and dry. Rain usually falls April–May and October–November.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

70 ethnic groups share about 40 languages. Strong clan and family links in rural areas are being weakened by urban migration. Poverty, severe drought, and years of high population growth exacerbate ethnic tensions.



**INSIGHT:** Kenya has more than 50 game reserves, national parks, and marine reservations



## THE ECONOMY

Tourism: image damaged by 2008 post-election violence. Flowers, tea, and coffee are cash crops. Needs food aid. Diversified manufacturing sector. Sizable informal economy.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Kenya

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1963

**CAPITAL:** Nairobi

**POPULATION:** 39.8 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 224,961 sq. miles  
(582,650 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 182 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Kiswahili\*, English\*, other

**RELIGIONS:** Christian 60%, traditional beliefs 25%, other 9%, Muslim 6%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Other 42%, Kikuyu 20%, Luhya 14%, Luo 13%, Kalenjin 11%

**GOVERNMENT:** Mixed presidential–parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Kenya shilling = 100 cents